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MUKESH PATEL SCHOOL OF
TECHNOLOGY MANAGEMENT
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MUNSOCIETY

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STUDY GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL

Agenda 1: Evaluating Mechanisms to safeguard Transit in International Straits

Agenda 2: Addressing Threats to Regional Stability in the Horn of Africa



Mumbai MUN'26

Letter from R&D

Dear Delegates,

The Department of Research & Development, MUN Society MPSTME, ecstatically welcomes all of you to the 13th edition of Mumbai MUN! Over the years, R&D has been guided by a singular ethos and vision: to make the Mumbai MUN conference a centre of meaningful discourse and debate on matters that rapidly shape the world we inhabit.

We are primarily tasked with formulating agendas and curating study guides that provide delegates with a comprehensive foundation before the conference. Our guides are the product of months of painstaking, human-driven research and production and are written with a *first-principles,* top-down approach.

Debate over matters of socio-political importance has taken centre stage in student life of late, with varying opinions and belief systems finding themselves continuously questioned. At Mumbai MUN 2026, as reflected by our theme "An Axiom Apart," we encourage delegates to bridge seemingly opposite truths and work together to creatively craft lasting solutions and partnerships.

With the *phare* that is our theme, our curations seek to foster meaningful and thought-provoking conversations on the topics that will define the global dynamics of the ever-changing world we live in. We seek to platform the perspectives that whittle away at the bureaucracy that barricades change.

The goal of any worthwhile MUN conference is to train the citizens of tomorrow to design, ideate, and create equitable world orders. The Research & Development team earnestly hopes Mumbai MUN 2026 will be a stepping stone for delegates to achieve that very goal.

Best wishes,
Department of Research & Development,
MUN Society MPSTME.

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Agenda 1: Evaluating Mechanisms to Safeguard Transit in International Straits

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

The United Nations Security Council is the preeminent global multilateral body that has an ascribed responsibility to maintain international peace and security. It addresses international threat vectors, acts as a forum for deliberation on the same, and relies on great powers to carry out measures to mitigate such threats. The Security Council is considered very powerful in terms of its implementation powers, which include international financial sanctions, trade embargoes, and international military interventions using global peacekeeping forces.[1] On the other hand, in recent years it has been criticised for its purported inability to exert its due influence and effectively implement the policies passed in its chamber. [2]

AGENDA OVERVIEW

This agenda is primarily concerned with the development of mechanisms that effectively safeguard commercial and other forms of transit in international straits. The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, signed in 1982, nearly universally enshrines the right to 'transit passage' in international straits.[3] Although the term 'international waters' is often used in many canonical legal documents, it lacks a precise definition, and therefore its usage has been stated to be dependent on legal context. In recent years and months, global maritime chokepoints have come under increasing duress, and maritime transit has been severely curtailed by states and non-state actors with the pretext of exercising national interest or prosecuting military interventions. [4]This agenda delves into the international legal fissures that have fomented these trends and provides delegates in the UNSC with the ability to arrive at multilateral approaches to mitigate the same.

DRIVERS

Piracy

Piracy has plagued logistical supply chains throughout history. The unique geography offered by a strait, being a narrow passage in international waters, leads to vessels passing through them becoming key targets for piracy.

The vulnerability of enforcement systems in the high seas is exploited by pirates, incentivised by the massive arbitrage opportunities offered by a potential payout. The narrative among pirates, however, differs from the perception of the international community. A common sentiment resonant amongst pirates is the idea of an independent 'coast guard', using the justification of defending national waters and taxing corporate trespassers. This is derived from the continuous exploitation of the affected communities, leading them to turn to crime on the high seas.[5] Overlapping and disputed maritime jurisdictions with limited patrols in

[1] *United Nations Security Council - Peace and security*. United Nations. (n.d.). https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en
[2] https://www.maastrichtdiplomat.org/post/the-un-security-council-victim-of-inefficiency-or-lack-of-legitimacy-in-international-relations
[3] https://prfworld.org/straits-transit-passage-and-conflict-unclos-and-laws-of-armed-conflict-at-sea/
[4] Strait of Hormuz disruptions: Implications for global trade and development |. (2026, March 10). UN Trade and Development (UNCTAD). https://unctad.org/publication/strait-hormuz-disruptions-implications-global-trade-and-development
[5] Somali Prison Survey Report. (n.d.-aa). https://www.unodc.org/documents/Piracy/SomaliPrisonSurveyReport.pdf

conflict-ridden areas lead to opportunistic maritime crime. Transport vessels serve as key targets for pirates because of their inherent lack of armed forces and the disproportionate financial motive for risk undertaken as part of the maritime crime operation.

State Action

Upwards of 80 per cent of global trade is transported through the sea, and a large proportion of global trade passes through narrow chokepoints.[6] Nations and other state actors can exploit these geographical vulnerabilities by leveraging their own geographies and vast military assets so as to obtain strategic advantages over adversaries. The willingness of state actors to enforce international maritime laws is one of the cornerstones of international trade. Conversely, the unwillingness of states to exercise and enforce such norms can lead to ripple effects that proliferate such state tendencies and further exacerbate disruptions of global maritime trade.[7]

Non-State Actions

Non-state actors often do not possess the resources and assets wielded by state actors but can still severely disrupt maritime chokepoints. These are often operationalised by relying on asymmetric warfare and low-cost technologies over critical waterways, forcing global trade networks to reroute without the need for a conventional navy.[8] A prominent contemporary example is that of the Houthis in Yemen. As a non-state actor that lacks international recognition by most states, it has significantly contributed towards disruptions seen on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, through which upwards of 10 per cent of global trade passes.[9]

MECHANISMS

Convention on the High Seas, 1958

Establishing the principle of freedom of navigation along with limiting unilateral interference with international shipping, the Convention on the High Seas, adopted during the first Convention on the Law of the Sea in 1958, promotes international cooperation against piracy, flag-state jurisdiction, and holding states responsible for the safety of transit.[10] It affirms freedom of navigation, fishing, and the freedom to fly over the high seas. Most crucially, it accords states lacking a sea coast the right to free transit through its territory.

The entire convention is divided into 37 articles, and the provisions of the Convention delineate maritime jurisdiction, safety protocols and security enforcement through structured legal frameworks. Articles 1 and 2 define the legal parameters of the "high seas" and articulate the fundamental principles governing the freedom of the seas, including the right to unrestricted navigation. This concept of jurisdictional foundation is expanded in Articles 4 through 7, which establish the legal framework of flag state by outlining criteria for vessel nationality and state accountability.

[6] https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints
[7] https://www.routledge.com/Seapower-A-Guide-for-the-Twenty-First-Century/Till/p/book/9781032877341 183-199
[8] https://www.hoover.org/research/changing-character-maritime-choke-points-who-throttles-whom
[9] https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cqy7z228kee30
[10] https://treaties.un.org/pages/viewdetails.aspx?src=treaty&mtdsg_no=xxi-2&chapter=21

Furthermore, Articles 8 and 9 codify the sovereign immunity of warships and state-owned vessels engaged exclusively in non-commercial government service. Regarding humanitarian and operational obligations, Articles 10 through 12 mandate strict international adherence to maritime safety standards and the universal duty of States to render assistance and conduct search-and-rescue operations for personnel and vessels in distress. Crucially for the maintenance of maritime security, Articles 14 through 21 codify the collective obligation of all States to cooperate in the suppression of piracy on the high seas. Finally, the Convention establishes operational parameters for transnational maritime law enforcement; Article 22 outlines the "right of visit," dictating the strict conditions under which warships may board foreign merchant vessels, while Article 23 delineates the legal doctrine of "hot pursuit" across maritime boundaries to ensure effective law enforcement.[11] It was superseded by UNCLOS III in 1982.

The Convention Regarding the Regime of the Straits (The Montreux Convention)

The Montreux Convention is a 1936 agreement governing the Bosphorus and Dardanelles straits in Turkey. It established provisions regulating the passage of vessels of war.[12]

Aircraft carriers, whether belonging to littoral States or not, cannot in any way transit the Turkish Straits. Only submarines belonging to littoral States may pass through the Turkish Straits for the purpose of rejoining their base in the Black Sea for the first time after their construction or purchase, or for the purpose of repair in dockyards outside the Black Sea.

The aggregate number and maximum aggregate tonnage of all foreign naval forces which may be in the course of passage through the Turkish Straits shall be limited to 9 and 15,000 tons respectively. The total maximum aggregate tonnage of non-littoral States in the Black Sea is 45.000 tons.

In this connection, the maximum aggregate tonnage of vessels of war which one non-littoral State may have in the Black Sea is 30.000 tons

War vessels of non-littoral States shall not be stationed in the Black Sea for more than 21 days. Intended passages through the Turkish Straits are notified to Türkiye through diplomatic channels. Notification time is: 8 days for vessels of war belonging to littoral States; 15 days for vessels of war belonging to non-littoral States.

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)

The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea is a legal framework for all marine and maritime activities. This international treaty replaced the four treaties of the 1958 Convention on the High Seas and is a result of the Third United Nations Conference on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS III). The Convention sets limits on areas measured from a baseline on the coast, such as the territorial sea, contiguous zone, exclusive economic zone (EEZs), extended continental shelf, internal waters and archipelagic waters.[13]

The Law also defines innocent and transit passage and the right to it, along with defining rules for passage of commercial vessels and non-commercial vessels, including warships.

[11] https://treaties.un.org/doc/Treaties/1963/01/19630103%2002-00%20AM/Ch_XXI_01_2_3_4_5p.pdf
[12] Republic of türkiye ministry of foreign affairs. (n.d.). Implementation of the Montreux Convention. https://www.mfa.gov.tr/implementation-of-the-montreux-convention.en.mfa

Defining the Straits covered by the transit-passage regime, Article 37 establishes special protections to be applied during international transit.[13]

Article 38, for international straits, protects freedom of navigation and overflight by guaranteeing unimpeded transit passage for ships and aircraft.[13] Balancing maritime safety and responsible conduct, freedom of transit is balanced by requiring continuous passage and compliance with navigation and compliance rules in Article 39.[13]

Article 40 restricts research and survey activities during transit without prior authorisation from bordering states. It helps prevent unauthorised surveys under the pretext of transit rights.[13]

To ease congestion and reduce accidents and collisions, Article 41 was established.[13] Article 42 permits regulations, but prohibits discrimination and practical denial of transit passage, while Article 44 prohibits bordering states from hampering transit passage and from impeding and suspending it.[13] Article 43 provides a legal basis for shared infrastructure and environmental protection between users and bordering states in Article 43.[13]

International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS)

Setting out minimum safety standards in the construction, equipment and operation of merchant ships, the International Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea is an international treaty that is required for signatories to the International Maritime Organisation convention to comply with.

Flag states are required to ensure that the ships under their flag comply with the requirements, and a series of certifications have to be achieved as proof that the standards are being complied with.

Chapter I sets out general provisions and requirements related to the application and implementation of the SOLAS Convention.[14]

Chapter II-1 of the SOLAS Convention deals with the ship's structural safety, subdivision, stability, machinery, and electrical equipment.[14]

Chapter II-2 describes the fire protection, detection, and extinguishing systems and means on board.[14]

Chapter III deals with the life-saving appliances and arrangements, which covers all aspects of life-saving equipment and its use, as well as the procedures for abandoning the ship.[14]

Chapter IV sets out the requirements related to radiocommunications onboard ships.[14]

Chapter V sets out the requirements related to navigation safety.[14]

Chapter VI deals with the carriage of cargoes and oil fuels and their impact on the safety of ships.[14]

Chapter VII sets out the requirements related to the safe carriage of dangerous goods and their impact on the environment.[14]

Chapter VIII deals with the nuclear-powered ships and their safety features.[14]

Chapter IX sets out the requirements related to safety management, the International Safety Management (ISM) Code, and the prevention of marine pollution.[14]

[13] https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/unclos_e.pdf

Chapter X deals with the high-speed craft and their safety requirements.[14]

Chapter XI-1 sets out special measures, including the mandatory ship identification, surveys, and inspections, which are applied to ensure maritime safety.[14]

Chapter XI-2 sets out special measures related to the International Ship and Port Facility Security (ISPS) Code, applied to ships to ensure their security against external threats.[14]

Chapter XII sets out additional safety requirements for bulk carriers to prevent adverse consequences in case of damage.[14]

Chapter XIII deals with the verification of compliance with the requirements and regulations of the SOLAS Convention, which is carried out under the IMO Member State Audit Scheme.[14]

Chapter XIV sets out the additional requirements for ships operating in polar waters, set out in the International Code for Ships Operating in Polar Waters (Polar Code).[14]

UN Verification and Inspection Mechanism (UNVIM)

At the request of the Government of Yemen, to ensure compliance with Resolution 2216 of the Security Council for vessels sailing to ports of Yemen not under its control. Managed and operated in Djibouti by the United Nations Office for Project Services. It facilitates and ensures unimpeded, free flow of commercial items to civilians in Yemeni territory not under its control.[15]

UNVIM issues clearance for vessels transporting commercial cargo through its website. Humanitarian vessels are exempt from needing clearance and should request clearance via the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) Deconfliction Cell.[15]

In order to facilitate commercial cargo flows into the country, in accordance with the UNSC Resolution 2216 (2015), UNOPS Operationalized UNVIM. The mechanism oversees the monitoring and inspection services of commercial and bilateral assistance cargo destined for Yemeni Red Sea ports.[16]

Bilateral assistance (bulk, break-bulk or containerised) from Member States destined for Yemen is subject to UNVIM clearance. Member States have to submit their clearance request with all relevant supporting documents attached.

MONITORING & ENFORCEMENT GAPS

Grey-Zone Exploitation

A maritime grey zone is an area where state and state-backed actors perform coercive or disruptive actions that do not cross the threshold into open conflict. Seemingly routine actions like surveying or patrolling are conducted with

[14] *International convention for the safety of life at sea (SOLAS), 1974*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/about/conventions/pages/international-convention-for-the-safety-of-life-at-sea-(solas),-1974.aspx

[15] *Unvim - United Nations Verification and inspection mechanism for Yemen*. UNVIM - United Nations Verification and Inspection Mechanism for Yemen. (n.d.). https://www.vimye.org/

[16] *In hindsight: The story of the UN verification and inspection mechanism in Yemen*. Security Council Report. (n.d.). https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/monthly-forecast/2016-09/the_story_of_the_un_verification_and_inspection_mechanism_in_yemen.php

discordant objectives like gathering intelligence or mapping neighbouring submarine infrastructure, but are not carried out openly or abrasively enough to blatantly break international laws and warrant a military response.[17] In Resolution A.1192(33), the IMO assembly described such ships engaged in illegal operations to circumvent sanctions or facilitate illegal maritime trafficking as shadow fleets, as "shadow fleets".[18] Such vessels manipulate their Automatic Identification System (AIS) and conduct ship-to-ship (STS) transfers of cargo to avoid flagging and regulation.

Article 40 of the UNCLOS prohibits foreign vessels from conducting research or survey activities during transit passage without the prior authorisation of the bordering States, but such activity can be carried out undeclared, and proving intent and illicit action falls upon the affected bordering States.[19] States can also carry out unauthorised mapping of the deep ocean floor under the guise of research, and use their collected data to prepare for military operations or sabotage.

Jurisdictional Limitations and Enforcement Gap

The UNCLOS allocates authority over oceans through a system of maritime zoning. Coastal States exercise full sovereignty in the seas within a certain distance, and hold partial sovereignty in extended regions (Contiguous and Extended Economic Zones).[20] On the high seas, a ship falls under the exclusive jurisdiction of its flag State (where the ship is registered) under its internal law, and a foreign warship may board it only if it is engaged in piracy, slave trade, unauthorised broadcasting, or is stateless. However, the definition of piracy outlines an illegal act committed for private gain on the high seas or outside the jurisdiction of any State, which excludes attacks on waters within any State's jurisdiction, even if limited, as well as those carried out for political ends. Under Article 111 of the UNCLOS, the right to hot pursuit ends upon the pursued vessel entering the territorial sea of its flag State, or a third State.

Resolution 1816 (2008) declared that states cooperating with the Transitional Federal Government (TFG) were authorised to enter Somali waters for a period of six months to combat piracy and armed robbery on the seas.[21] The resolution was subsequently extended until its expiration in March 2022, with the Somalian government insisting that their primary objective of repressing piracy had been achieved.[22]

Systemic Inadequacies

The governance of maritime law by multiple frameworks and authorities, each addressing problems separately and relying on opt-in State compliance rather than a singular system, results in a fragmented landscape that easily allows

[17] Sood, A. (2026, September 24). *What is Grey Zone in the Maritime Context?* OCIANA. https://ociana.com/what-is-grey-zone-in-the-maritime-context/
[18] RESOLUTION A.1192(33) - *URGING MEMBER STATES AND ALL RELEVANT STAKEHOLDERS TO PROMOTE ACTIONS TO PREVENT ILLEGAL OPERATIONS IN THE MARITIME SECTOR BY THE "DARK FLEET" OR "SHADOW FLEET"* - Netherlands Regulatory Framework (NERF) – Maritime. (n.d.-b). https://puc.overheid.nl/nsi/doc/PUC_779942_14/1/
[19] Affairs, U. N. O. O. L. (2004). United Nations convention on the law of the sea. *Law of the Sea Bulletin*, *2004* (55), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.18356/248167ed-en
[20] Affairs, U. N. O. O. L. (2004). United Nations convention on the law of the sea. *Law of the Sea Bulletin*, *2004* (55), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.18356/248167ed-en
[21] *U.N. Security Council, S/Res/1816,* (2008). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/627953
[22] *Is Somali piracy finally under control? | ISS Africa.* (n.d.). ISS Africa. https://issafrica.org/iss-today/is-somali-piracy-finally-under-control

illicit activities on the high seas as well as territorial seas to go unacted upon. The IMO's Member State Audit Scheme makes every Member State subject to periodic audits based on Resolution A.1211(34), but the State alone is responsible for implementing any actions to address deficiencies found during the audit, and the IMO does not hold any enforcement authority.[23]

It does not possess the right to inspection and imposition of sanctions in case of non-compliance. Monitoring is similarly dependent on voluntary compliance by States and vessels, and Regulation 19-1 of SOLAS Chapter V allows the master of a vessel to switch off the AIS if its operation could compromise the safety of the vessel, a provision that can be readily abused.[24]

Legal Ambiguities

UNCLOS recognises two principal kinds of passage. Passage is innocent so long as it is not prejudicial to the peace, good order, or security of the bordering coastal State. Transit passage is freedom of navigation and overflight solely for the purpose of continuous and expeditious transit of an internationally significant strait. In straits excluded from the application of the regime of transit passage, innocent passage applies and likewise cannot be suspended under Article 45. In the territorial sea, Article 25 allows a coastal State to temporarily suspend innocent passage in specified areas when essential for its protection.[25]

Two ambiguities arise from these laws. First, 'prejudicial to security' is a standard that States may invoke subjectively. A State that denies a strait's international character can argue that only the more qualified regime of innocent passage applies. Second, UNCLOS binds only its ratifying parties, and not every State bordering a strategic strait has ratified it. States that have not ratified the Convention, such as Iran, maintain that allowing transit passage is obligatory only to ratifying parties, and recognise only innocent passage, which may be suspended under Article 25.[26]

Fragile State Dynamics

Fragile state dynamics constitute a significant structural impediment to the effective monitoring and enforcement of mechanisms designed to safeguard transit through international straits. National maritime agencies often lack the operational resources, trained personnel, and sustained budgetary support required to maintain continuous surveillance of critical waterways. Weak command structures, outdated vessel-tracking systems, and limited inter-agency coordination further degrade the ability of authorities to detect, deter, or respond to threats ranging from piracy and armed robbery at sea to illicit trafficking and deliberate interference with commercial shipping.[27] Fragile

[23] *Member State Audit Scheme*. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/msas/pages/default.aspx
[24] *Inte,rnational Convention for the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS), 1974*. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/about/conventions/pages/international-convention-for-the-safety-of-life-at-sea-(solas),,-1974.aspx
[25] Affairs, U. N. O. O. L. (2004). United Nations convention on the law of the sea. *Law of the Sea Bulletin, 2004* (55), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.18356/248167ed-en
[26] *Charges for passage in the Strait of Hormuz: the law governing tolls and service fees in straits used for international navigation*. (2026, October 20). ASIL. https://asil.org/insights/volume-30-issue-10/
[27] Jacobsen, K. L., Bruwer, C., & Rasmussen, A. M. (2026, February 3). Fragile States Dynamics. https://sjms.nu/articles/10.31374/sjms.410

governance also impairs the reliable exercise of flag State and coastal State responsibilities under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea. Information-sharing arrangements with regional and international partners are frequently constrained by institutional mistrust, technical incompatibilities, or the prioritisation of domestic security concerns over maritime domain awareness.[28]

Moreover, prolonged fragility can generate secondary effects that extend beyond national borders. Displacement of maritime criminal activity into adjacent straits, erosion of confidence among commercial operators, and increased reliance on unilateral or coalition-based enforcement measures risk fragmenting the cooperative architecture intended to uphold transit rights.

KEY ACTORS

Strait-Bordering States

Malacca Strait Protocol along SOMS

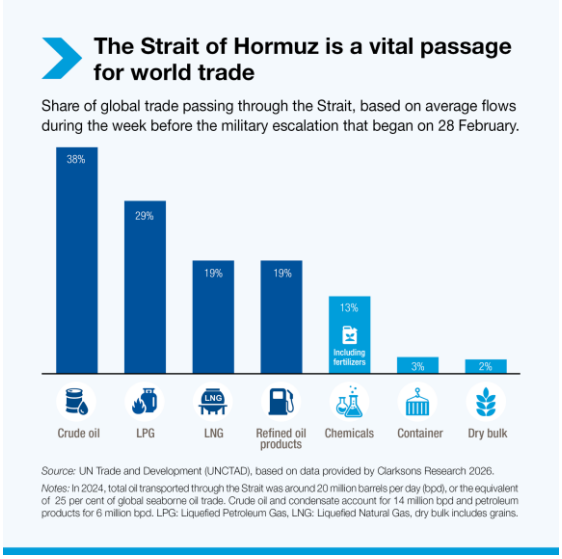
The Strait of Malacca lies between the Malay Peninsula and the Indonesian island of Sumatra, while the Strait of Singapore lies between the island of Singapore in the north and the Indonesian islands of Riau in the south.

The Straits of Malacca and Singapore (SOMS) are regulated by a set of practical co-operative measures known as the Malacca Strait Protocol.[1] Its member states are Malaysia, Singapore, Indonesia and Thailand. SOMS waterways are critical and strategic to the global trading system. 70% of Asia's oil imports and ~50% of the world's total annual seaborne trade tonnage pass through the straits.[16] Co-operation between the littoral, international and user states is necessary to maintain safety and security of all users of the straits.[29]

The GCC and Iran along the Strait of Hormuz

The Strait of Hormuz lies between the Gulf of Oman and the Persian Gulf. It separates the Arabian Peninsula and Iran.

The states in the Gulf Cooperation Council and Iran access the Strait of Hormuz, which accounts for ~20% of the world's liquefied natural gas and ~38% of seaborne oil trade.[30] It is also a major route for transportation of petroleum products around the globe. Disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have transmitted shock waves across supply chains and commodity markets, and have caused socio-economic implications for neighbouring countries as well as other nations.



[28] Basu, P. (2026, July 10). Information-sharing arrangements. https://www.orfonline.org/research/who-sees-the-sea-capacity-building-as-the-foundation-of-maritime-domain-awareness

[29] Ministry of Defence, Singapore. (n.d.). *Fact sheet: The Malacca Straits Patrol*. Ministry of Defence. https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/2016apr21-news-releases-00134/

[30] *Strait of Hormuz disruptions: Implications for Global Trade and Development*. United Nations Trade and Development. (n.d.). https://unctad.org/publication/strait-hormuz-disruptions-implications-global-trade-and-development

Trade Statistics for the Strait of Hormuz
Source: UNCTAD

States along the Straits of Bab el-Mandeb and Tiran

The Strait of Bab el-Mandeb is an important waterway for transit from the Gulf of Aden to the Red Sea and further to the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean. Transit through the Bab-el-Mandeb is limited to two 2-mile-wide channels for inbound and outbound shipments.

For global seaborne commodity and goods shipments, the strait is one of the world's most important routes, particularly from Asia to Europe via the Suez Canal. It is also vital for traffic from the Suez-Mediterranean pipeline on Egypt's Red Sea coast, as well as commodities bound for Asia, including Russian oil. In 2025, 4.2 million barrels of crude oil and other liquid petroleum products passed through the strait every day. Total oil shipments via these routes accounted for about 6% of total seaborne-traded oil [31]

Turkey along the Strait of Bosphorus and Dardanelles

The Straits of Bosphorus and Dardanelles are a set of straits that lie under Turkish jurisdiction. The Strait of Bosporus passes directly through Istanbul, while the Dardanelles connects the Sea of Marmara to the Aegean Sea.

The Montreux Convention is the legal framework governing passage through the straits. Turkey has introduced mechanisms like the Maritime Traffic Regulations for the Turkish Straits, which enforce strict rules governing navigation, reporting, and safety across the İstanbul Strait, Çanakkale Strait, and the Sea of Marmara, such as Pilotage Threshold, Bridge Clearance, Emergency Salvage, and Seaworthiness.

Major Trading Powers

G7 Nations

Strongly adhering to UNCLOS and promoting freedom of navigation and unimpeded transit through international straits, they support Universal Open Access. They have committed to actively securing shipping lanes against disruptions by deploying naval coalitions. They have exposure in straits such as the Strait of Malacca, Bab-el-Mandeb, and the Taiwan Strait. The 7 nations account for roughly 25% of global trade, and the wider Western alliance elevates the percentage to nearly 40% of the world's total trade value.

Eurasian Core Nations

Prioritising sovereign jurisdiction and control, they counter Western sanctions by using straits as geopolitical choke points, protecting their own supply lines and using blockades to restrict and threaten adversarial trade. China, Iran and Russia have access to the Strait of Hormuz, the Taiwan Strait and the Bering Strait. They account for nearly 32% to 35% of global trade.

Non-Aligned Nations

Majorly, Non-Aligned Nations support UNCLOS as the foundational legal mechanism governing maritime transit, and highly favour burden-sharing frameworks that do not compromise local sovereignty. The premier model for this is the Cooperative Mechanism for the Straits of Malacca and Singapore. They account for nearly 30% of the global seaborne trade.

[31] *world oil transport chokepoints*. International - U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA). (n.d.). https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints

PAST INTERNATIONAL ACTION

United Nations Security Council Resolutions

In Resolution 1816 (2008), the UNSC authorised states cooperating with the TFG of Somalia to enter Somali territorial waters to fight piracy, and this authorisation was further extended with more resolutions until its expiration in March 2022. Resolution 2216 (2015) imposed an arms embargo on the Houthis and called for inspection of any ships bound for Yemen, which gave rise to the UNVIM, amid complete blockades from a Saudi-led coalition. Resolution 2722 (2024) demanded that the Houthis cease attacks on merchant vessels.

On 7 April 2026, a resolution aiming to boost security in the Strait of Hormuz was vetoed by China and Russia.

International Maritime Organisation (IMO)

As the specialised agency of the United Nations responsible for the safety, security and environmental performance of global shipping, the International Maritime Organisation (IMO) has played a central role in establishing the administrative and legal architecture necessary to safeguard transit through international straits.[32] Historically, the IMO responded to evolving threats by formalising regulatory frameworks, notably the International Ship and Port Facility Security (ISPS) Code. Adopted as an amendment to the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS) Convention, the ISPS Code established a comprehensive risk management framework that mandates strict security protocols for government vessels and commercial port infrastructure.[33] Furthermore, the IMO created the Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts Against the Safety of Maritime Navigation (SUA Convention), which encourages States to penalise and prosecute non-state actors who hijack or endanger maritime navigation.[34] Beyond conventions, the IMO has actively enhanced regional cooperation and maritime domain awareness through strategic frameworks such as the Djibouti Code of Conduct.[35]

Administrative Regulation

Administrative Regulation constitutes a critical pillar in the multilateral framework designed to safeguard international straits, operating at the complex intersection of sovereign jurisdiction and the universal freedom of navigation. Under the legal architecture established by the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), under the regime of transit passage, States bordering straits are strictly prohibited from impeding or suspending the continuous and expeditious transit of foreign vessels. However, to mitigate the inherent risks of maritime congestion, environmental degradation, and security threats, UNCLOS explicitly authorises littoral States to enact and enforce domestic administrative regulations. To prevent unilateral overreach and the arbitrary disruption of global commerce, these national regulations must strictly abide by generally accepted international regulations, procedures,

[32] INTERNATIONAL MARITIME ORGANIZATION. (n.d.-r). Role of the IMO. https://www.imo.org/en/about/pages/default.aspx
[33] *SOLAS XI-2 and the ISPS Code*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/security/pages/solas-xi-2%20isps%20code.aspx
[34] *Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts Against the Safety of Maritime Navigation*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.-a). https://www.imo.org/en/about/conventions/pages/sua-treaties.aspx
[35] *The Djibouti Code of Conduct*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.-c). https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/security/pages/content-and-evolution-of-the-djibouti-code-of-conduct.aspx

and practices, ensuring that the governance of vital maritime chokepoints remains legally standardised, predictable, and cooperative.[36] Furthermore, mandatory reporting and routing mechanisms such as Traffic Separation Schemes (TSS) and Mandatory Ship Reporting Systems (SRS) significantly enhance the Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) of fragile and robust littoral States alike.[37]

Concurrently, environmental administrative regulations, guided by the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (MARPOL), impose strict operational guidelines regarding the discharge of oil, noxious liquid substances, and ballast water, thereby protecting the delicate marine ecosystems of narrow straits from the catastrophic impacts of maritime transit.[38]

Sanctions & Multinational Action

To enforce maritime security and deter severe disruptions to international shipping, the international community has consistently relied upon targeted sanctions and the deployment of multinational naval coalitions, frequently operating under the direct authorisation of the United Nations Security Council. Recognising that the obstruction of critical maritime straits constitutes a threat to international peace and security, the Security Council has repeatedly invoked Chapter VII of the UN Charter to impose targeted sanctions including arms embargoes, asset freezes, and travel bans against piracy syndicates and armed groups operating in littoral zones.[39] Concurrently, the Security Council has established vital legal precedents through pivotal resolutions, such as Resolution 1816 (2008) and its successors regarding the Horn of Africa, which authorised foreign naval forces to enter the territorial waters of a fragile State to repress acts of piracy and armed robbery at sea.[40] These robust legal mandates have catalysed the formation of sophisticated multinational maritime security architectures, including the Combined Maritime Forces (CMF), the European Union Naval Force (EU NAVFOR) Operation Atalanta, and NATO's Operation Ocean Shield.

CASE STUDIES

The Corfu Channel Incident

The Corfu Channel, or the Straits of Corfu, is a narrow body of water with the coasts of Greece and Albania on the east and the Greek island of Corfu on the west. It provides passage between the Adriatic and the Ionian Sea, and is used by local shipping and tourists, as well as supporting a minority of international tourism. Due to the extremely rocky nature of the strait, ships have to sail close to the Albanian coast. [41]

On 15 May 1946, amidst the onset of the Greek Civil War, British ships were fired upon by

[36] *United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), 1982, Part III (Straits Used for International Navigation)*. United Nations. (n.d.). https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/part3.htm
[37] *Traffic Separation Schemes (TSS) and Mandatory Ship Reporting Systems (SRS)*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.-d). https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/safety/pages/shipsrouteing.aspx
[38] *International convention for the prevention of pollution from ships (MARPOL)*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.-b). https://www.imo.org/en/about/conventions/pages/international-convention-for-the-prevention-of-pollution-from-ships-(marpol).aspx
[39] *Chapter VII: Action with respect to threats to the peace, breaches of the peace, and acts of aggression*. United Nations. (n.d.-a). https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/chapter-7
[40] *United Nations Security Council Resolution 1816 (2008)*. United Nations Digital Library. (n.d.). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/627953?ln=en
[41] Delgado, J. (2014, May). Cold war in the corfu. *Military History*, *31*, 36.

Albanian shore batteries in the Corfu Channel, the shells coming within 200 yards of the two cruisers HMS Orion and HMS Superb.[42]

After 5 months, on 22 October 1946, a British flotilla was passing close to the Albanian coast, in what they considered to be a mine-free zone. Near the bay of Saranda, the destroyer HMS Saumarez was heavily damaged after it struck a mine. Just more than an hour later, while towing the damaged Saumarez, the destroyer HMS Volage also struck a mine and sustained heavy damage. After twelve hours of effort, all ships managed to reach Corfu harbour. The damage to the Volage was repairable, but the Saumarez was damaged beyond repair. In the aftermath, 44 men had lost their lives, and 42 more were injured as a result of the incident.[43]

In response, the British launched Operation Retail, in which the British navy undertook mine clearance operations on the 12th and 13th of November in Albanian territorial waters without advance permission from the country.[44]

Growing pro-Soviet sentiment in the Albanian government and the British government's eagerness to assert a strong naval role in the region caused the Albanian government to formally submit a complaint to the United Nations, describing Operation Retail as an incursion into Albanian territory.[45]

The government of the United Kingdom, on 9th December, demanded reparations from Albania for the deaths of 44 sailors, 42 injured and the two damaged ships. The Albanian government denied involvement in the laying of mines and insisted on Greece having done so.[46]

The Security Council heard the complaint that the British raised. A resolution that would accuse Albania of indirect involvement in the mine laying was proposed but was vetoed by the Soviet Union, and the veto was also backed by Poland.

On 9 April 1947, a resolution was passed, with the Soviet Union and Poland abstaining, recommending the dispute be resolved in the International Court of Justice.

In 1949, the ICJ issued its merits judgment, ruling partly in favour of the United Kingdom, stating that the flotilla did not violate Albanian territorial waters, basing its decision on the character of international straits being determined by their connection to two parts of the high seas, and that the strait was used for international navigation.[47]

The Court also held that during times of peace, the right of innocent passage existed through straits like the Corfu Channel which connected two parts of the high seas. It maintained that some Albanian regulation of passage is acceptable, but not to the extent of demanding authorisation or barring the passage of warships through the channel.

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[42] Gardiner, L. (1966). *The Eagle spreads his claws: A history of the Corfu Channel dispute and of Albania's relations with the West, 1945-1965*. Blackwood.
[43] *Albania (British note)*. The UK Parliament API. (n.d.). https://api.parliament.uk/historic-hansard/commons/1946/dec/11/albania-british-note
[44] *Corfu Channel (United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland v. Albania)*. INTERNATIONAL COURT OF JUSTICE. (n.d.). https://www.icj-cij.org/case/1
[45] Xhaferri, M., & Tase, M. (2024). Analysis of Albania's diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union during the years 1948-1959. F1000Research, 11, 1441. https://doi.org/10.12688/f1000research.126497.2
[46] Albania rejects British note. (1946, December 31). *Manchester Guardian*, pp. 5–5.
[47] https://www.icj-cij.org/sites/default/files/case-related/1/001-19490409-JUD-01-00-EN.pdf

It also held that manifestation of a policy of force has in the past given rise to the most serious abuses and cannot, whatever be the present defects in international organisation, find a place in international law. It rejected British arguments of Operation Retail being justified as self-protection, maintaining that "respect for territorial sovereignty is an essential foundation of international relations."

This case has often been hailed as a defining case in the development of the law of the sea. The seventh session of the ILC submitted a draft provision to the 1958 UNCLOS. It provided that the right of innocent passage through international straits should not be suspended. Innocent passage as well as transit passage were integrated into the 1982 UNCLOS, which superseded the Convention on the Territorial Sea and the Contiguous Zone.

The Malacca and Bab el-Mandeb Paradigms

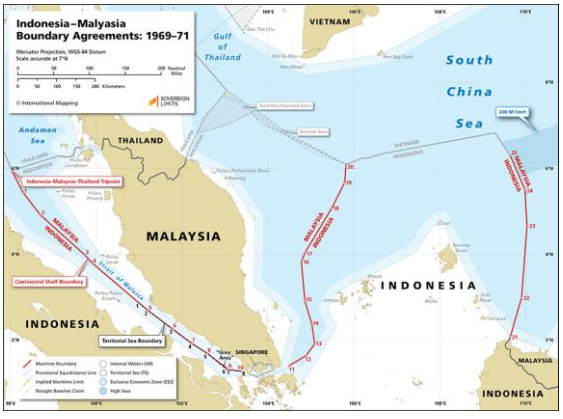
The Strait of Malacca is a vital waterway that provides passage and transit from the Indian Ocean to the Sea of South China. Over 60,000 vessels use the strait annually, with 30 per cent of world trade and 50 per cent of world energy needs passing through the strait each year. Security is a concern for both littoral and user states.

In 2004, the United States proposed the Regional Maritime Security Initiative, which would have established an American naval presence in Indonesia and Malaysia, but both nations rejected the proposal.

The 2005 Shangri-La Dialogue agreed on three basic principles: that it is the responsibility of the littoral states to maintain maritime security in the Strait, but the international community, agencies and major user states have a role to play, and that the measures undertaken should be respectful of the sovereignty of the littoral states and in accordance with international law.

[48]The Malacca Straits Protocol emerged in 2004 through regional cooperation and reflects the principles agreed upon in the 2005 Shangri-La dialogue. It has three principal components.

The Malacca Straits Sea Protocol conducts regular patrols in participating states' respective waters, sharing information about suspicious vessels and incidents, and improving communication between national maritime operations centres. It coordinates response to piracy and armed robbery, reducing gaps in surveillance. However, coordinated control does not give a country unrestricted access to another country's territorial waters. Littoral states have jurisdiction over marine resources and the preservation and protection of the marine environment, and ships of any nation might take enforcement action against offences as directed and required by international law.



Territorial waters in the Strait of Malacca
Source: Sovereign Limits

[48] *Keynote address by minister for Education and Second minister for defence dr Ng Eng Hen, at the 1st International Maritime Security Conference*. Ministry of Defence. (2026, July 30). https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/2009may13-speeches-00271/

Eyes-in-the-Sky (EiS) supplements MSSP with maritime aerial surveillance, increasing coverage to reinforce sea patrol.[49] It offers a wider range and faster identification time for potential threats, suspicious vessel movements, and local incidents.

The Intelligence Exchange Group (IEG) led to the development and implementation of an information-sharing platform called the Malacca Straits Protocol Information System (MSP-IS), which is managed by the Information Fusion Centre (IFC), using which air and sea assets deployed on scene can quickly pass information of incidents to all Monitoring and Action Agencies (MAAs) on a real-time basis, which enhances shared situation awareness and facilitates response co-ordination.[49]

ReCAAP, or the Regional Cooperation Agreement on Combating Piracy and Armed Robbery against Ships in Asia works to set up an information network and a cooperation regime to prevent piracy and armed robbery against ships in regional waters.[50]

The Cooperative Mechanism was launched in September 2007 under the International Maritime Organisation (IMO). The Co-operative Mechanism brings together the littoral States (Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore), user States, and other stakeholders to share information, coordinate initiatives, and work together to promote navigational safety and environmental protection.[51]

Cooperation Forum provides a platform for littoral states, user states, shipping representatives, and other stakeholders to discuss shared concerns. Project Coordination Committee coordinates and oversees agreed cooperative projects. Aids to Navigation Fund supports maintenance, repair, and replacement of navigational aids. [51]

The Strait of Bab-el-Mandeb has faced a combination of maritime insecurity, political fragmentation, and armed conflict, which has made sustained cooperation difficult.

Operation Prosperity Guardian is a 2023 U.S. Navy-led coalition to protect shipping lanes through the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden from Houthi attacks. It is a multinational coalition established under the umbrella of the Combined Maritime Forces, with a focus on Maritime Security in the region.[52]

The European Navy launched EUNAVFOR ASPIDES to safeguard transit through the Strait by forming a multinational European coalition to maintain security in shipping lanes, coordinating with Operation Prosperity Guardian and the Combined Maritime Forces.[53]

Coastal authority in the region is fragmented and unable to provide security through the Strait,

[49] *Fact sheet: The Malacca Straits Patrol*. Ministry of Defence. (n.d.). https://www.mindef.gov.sg/news-and-events/latest-releases/2016apr21-news-releases-00134/

[50] https://www.files.ethz.ch/isn/26417/IDSS%20S&S%20book.pdf

[51] *Safety of straits used for International Navigation*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/mediacentre/hottopics/pages/faq-safety-of-straits-used-for-international-navigation-.aspx

[52] *Statement from secretary of Defense Lloyd J. Austin III on ensuring freedom of navigation*. U.S. Department of War. (n.d.). https://www.war.gov/News/Releases/Release/Article/3621110/statement-from-secretary-of-defense-lloyd-j-austin-iii-on-ensuring-freedom-of-n/

[53] Eunavfor operation aspides | EEAS - european union. (n.d.-a). https://www.eeas.europa.eu/eunavfor-aspides_en?s=410381

with a recent surge in piracy, hijacking and ship seizures, unlike the Strait of Malacca, where Littoral states coordinate to maintain security in the region. International coalitions provide security in the Strait.

The Strait of Hormuz Crisis

The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow waterway connecting the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea. At its narrowest point, it measures approximately 21 nautical miles, making it one of the world's most critical maritime chokepoints. A substantial proportion of global oil and liquefied natural gas exports, estimated at around one-fifth of the world's total, transits the Strait daily, rendering the security of navigation through this corridor a matter of significant international concern.[54]a

This strategic importance of the Strait has made it a focal point of regional and international tensions. During the Iran–Iraq War (1980–1988), both parties targeted commercial shipping in what became known as the "Tanker War".[55]a

Attacks on oil tankers, the use of naval mines, and related disruptions prompted international naval involvement, including escort operations by the United States and other States, aimed at ensuring the continued flow of energy supplies.

In more recent years, the Strait has been featured prominently in situations of heightened tension. In 2019, a series of incidents involving damage to commercial tankers in the Gulf of Oman and the seizure of vessels in or near the Strait raised concerns regarding the safety of international navigation[56].

The legal framework governing the Strait is primarily derived from the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), particularly the regime of transit passage applicable to straits used for international navigation. Under this regime, ships and aircraft of all States enjoy the right of continuous and expeditious transit that shall not be impeded. The International Maritime Organisation has also established a Traffic Separation Scheme in the Strait to promote the safe passage of vessels.[57]a

Recurring threats to navigation in the Strait, whether arising from state actions, non-state actors, or broader geopolitical tensions, have repeatedly drawn the attention of the international community. Such disruptions have the potential to affect global energy markets, increase shipping costs, and generate wider implications for international peace and security.

CONCLUSION

The protection of transit through international straits remains a matter of enduring importance for the maintenance of international peace and security. These maritime corridors serve as vital pipelines of global commerce and energy supply, and disruptions to their free and secure use can generate global economic and strategic consequences. Existing legal frameworks,

[54] *U.S. Energy Information Administration - EIA - independent statistics and analysis*. International - U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA). (n.d.). https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints"

[55] The first tanker war with Iran | history today. (n.d.-b). https://www.historytoday.com/history-matters/first-tanker-war

[56] *GPS spoofing incident involving British oil tanker "Stena Impero" in Strait of Hormuz (Persian Gulf)*. Map. (n.d.). https://maritimecybersecurity.nl/incident/Zka6NwqmKM

[57] United Nations. (n.d.). *United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea*. United Nations. https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/part3.htm

particularly the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, together with instruments developed under the guidelines of the International Maritime Organisation and measures authorised by the Security Council, provide a substantial foundation for safeguarding navigation.

At the same time, the persistence of threats ranging from piracy and armed robbery to geopolitical tensions and non-state actor interference underscores the need for continued vigilance and effective implementation. The Security Council, by virtue of its primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security, is uniquely placed to review the adequacy of current mechanisms, strengthen coordination among relevant actors, and consider further practical measures that reinforce the safety and security of international straits while upholding the principles of freedom of navigation and the sovereign rights of coastal St

Agenda 2: Addressing Threats to Regional Stability in the Horn of Africa

AGENDA OVERVIEW

The Horn of Africa has in recent years been fraught with conflicts that have had deep economic and humanitarian ramifications on local populations. This has resulted in the forced displacement of upwards of 24.7 million people, with the local population accounting for a fifth of all people in need of humanitarian aid worldwide. The reverberating repercussions of colonialism resonate through the conflict today, with the primary incentive historically and contemporarily being control over the Red Sea and Trade routes.

Tensions amongst former allies Ethiopia and Eritrea have led to cross-border disputes following the Ethiopian push for direct Red Sea access. Ethiopia also continues to suffer from internal strife, with manmade famines and armed conflicts leading to death tolls in the order of hundreds of thousands. Recent efforts to reduce mutual hostilities have failed to deter the proxy dynamics that, in turn, fund and arm the propagation of these conflicts. A significant part of deliberation would be focused on measures to sustainably mitigate threats to stability and ensure long-term cessation of hostilities in the Horn of Africa.

INTRODUCTION TO THE HORN OF AFRICA

Political Geography

The United Nations Terminology Database (UNTERM) defines the core Horn of Africa as the easternmost extension of African land comprising Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia, and Somalia.[58]

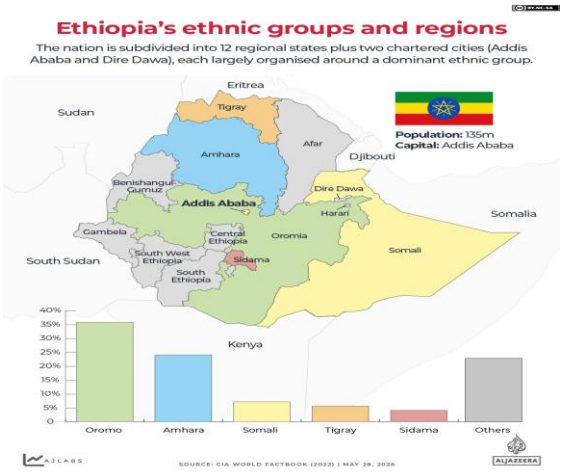
The region comprises four nations whose people share a joint tribal, cultural, and occupational history. The borders separating the four countries were drawn during Africa's colonisation. Hence, multiple marginalised communities often straddle the countries' borders, a phenomenon political scientists have noted that has been used to weaponise ethnic groups as proxies in war.[59]

[58] UNTERM. (n.d.). https://unterm.un.org/unterm2/en/view/UNHQ/1ca60895-18ad-43d1-b362-acb3bca69b9f
[59] CIRSD. (2026, February 2). The Horn of Africa - Its strategic importance for Europe, the Gulf States, and beyond - CIRSD. https://cirsd.org/horizon-article/the-horn-of-africa-its-strategic-importance-for-europe-the-gulf-states-and-beyond/

The Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia comprises over half of the Horn's total land area. The world's most populous landlocked sovereign state, it is one of the world's fastest-growing nations, both by population and economy.

The Federation is divided into twelve ethno-linguistically based regional states, with two chartered cities: the capital of Addis Ababa in the centre of the country and Dire Dawa near the troubled Oromia region. Dire Dawa was originally brought under federal control to reduce tensions after the Oromo and the Somali Regional State both staked their claim on the city. It was granted further autonomy in 2004 by making it a chartered city.[60]

Ethiopia's federal setup provides significant autonomy to regions, with Article 39 of the Ethiopian Constitution even guaranteeing the right of "every Nation, Nationality and People" to secession.[61] These regions are divided into zones, which are further subdivided into woredas or districts. Additionally, certain districts are granted further autonomy and report directly to the regional state government. These are termed "special woredas."[62]



Ethiopia's ethnic division
Source: Al Jazeera

Eritrea is located to the north of Ethiopia, with the Red Sea to the east and Sudan to the west. The country is divided into six administrative regions, with its capital, Asmara, in the Central Region.

The UN Commission of Inquiry on Human Rights in Eritrea has classified Eritrea as an authoritarian state, with no elections being held after independence. Isaias Afwerki has served as President since Independence, and has not implemented the 1997 Eritrean Constitution.[63]

Although a small country by land size, Djibouti finds itself uniquely advantaged by its location on the Gulf of Aden and its proximity to the Bab-el-

[60]Aalen, L. (2006). Ethnic Federalism and Self-Determination for Nationalities in a Semi-Authoritarian State: the Case of Ethiopia. International Journal on Minority and Group Rights, 13(2-3), 243-261. https://doi.org/10.1163/157181106777909849
[61]FEDERAL NEGARIT GAZET A OF THE FEDERAL DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC OF ETHIOPIA. (1995). In FEDERAL NEGARIT GAZET A. https://www.ethiopianembassy.be/wp-content/uploads/Constitution-of-the-FDRE.pdf
[62]Debelo, A. R., Hidoto, Y. C., & Rift Valley Institute. (2024). NEW CLUSTER REGIONS AND DISTRIBUTIVE STRUGGLES IN SOUTHERN ETHIOPIA: BOUNDARY CONFLICTS IN THE ZEYSE–GAMO AND KABENA–GURAGE BORDERLANDS. In Rift Valley Institute, Rift Valley Institute | Peace Research Facility [Report]. https://riftvalley.net/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/New-Cluster-Regions-and-Distributive-Struggles_v4.pdf
[63] The Trustees of Princeton University. (n.d.). Eritrea 1997. Princeton University. https://pcwcr.princeton.edu/reports/eritrea1997.html

Mandeb Strait, one of the world's most important shipping lanes.[64]

Bolstered by its strategic position on the Strait, Djibouti has emerged as a key location for foreign military bases, with the tiny nation housing at least eight in 2024.[65] The relatively young nation of 1.2 million also boasts the Horn's highest GDP per capita, with projections estimating USD 4560 for 2026.

The Horn of Africa is sometimes referred to as the Somali Peninsula, as Somalia's shape provides the region with its distinctive "horn." With a population over 19 million, Somalia is a key power in the region. The nation has faced insurgent threats for decades, which prominently include the al-Shabaab militant group. Insurgent organisations still control major sections of the country. The Republic of Somaliland, forming a significant portion in the northwest, has declared independence from Somalia, but only a handful of nations recognise its sovereignty.

Physical Geography

The Horn of Africa (HOA), also known as the Somali Peninsula, is geographically located on the eastern side of mainland Africa. It is bordered by the Arabian Sea in the north, the Gulf of Aden, and the Indian Ocean. The peninsula protrudes from the mainland, resembling a horn-like shape. Major physical features include:

The Horn of Africa sits right next to one of the most important trading routes for global maritime trade, the Red Sea. Nearly 12 to 15% of global trade happens through this body of water every year. The vicinity of such a geopolitically important trade route to the Horn of Africa makes the internal stability in the region an international interest.

Furthermore, in the Red Sea there is the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait, a narrow passage which can easily become a major chokepoint, stopping all transit through the Red Sea. This will result in major setbacks to trade and commerce internationally.

HISTORY OF THE REGION

Pre-Independence Era

During the 19th century, the northeastern Horn of Africa along the Red Sea became a significant region with its close proximity to the major maritime trade routes, which piqued the interest of European colonisers. Italy slowly established control over parts of the Eritrean coast with its acquisition of Assab in 1869. By 1890, Italy formally established the colony of Eritrea. Italian rule separated the territory of Eritrea and Ethiopia politically; even then, the populations of Eritrea and northern Ethiopia highlands continued to share cultural, linguistic, and religious connections. Italy developed infrastructure and developed ports and transportation networks, such as ports like Massawa and the highland city of Asmara. Italy's further colonial expansion brought it directly into conflict with Ethiopia. In 1896, at the Battle of Adwa, Ethiopian forces defeated Italy, preventing Italy from conquering Ethiopia at that time, though Eritrea continued to remain under Italian colonial rule.

In 1935, the Fascist Italian government launched another invasion of Ethiopia by using Eritrea as a launching base for the Italian military. After the

[64] Abdallah, N. (2026, September 10). Explainer: Why is the Bab el-Mandeb Strait so important? https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/why-is-bab-el-mandeb-strait-so-important-2026-09-10
[65] Djibouti: The tiny valuable nation hosting the world's military giants. (n.d.). Global Affairs and Strategic Studies. https://www.unav.edu/web/global-affairs/djibouti-the-tiny-valuable-nation-hosting-the-world-s-military-giants

successful invasion, Ethiopia became part of Greater Italian East Africa; Italian control united the region, which included Eritrea, Ethiopia, and Somalia. This period showed the strategic importance of the Horn of Africa, and its location near the Red Sea allowed Italy to maintain dominance over major maritime trade routes. In 1941, the British forces defeated the Italian forces in the Horn of Africa, which subsequently handed control of Eritrea to the British administration. [66]

Post-Colonial Conflicts

In 1952, the United Nations established a federation between Eritrea and Ethiopia, with the Ethiopian Crown at the centre and Eritrea receiving autonomous status with its own parliament and constitution, while Ethiopia held responsibility for foreign affairs and defence. The Eritrean constitution was adopted in July 1952, and the Federation came into effect on 11 September 1952. Britain then transferred control of Eritrea to the Federal Ethiopian and Eritrean authorities. The Federation proved short-lived, and in the following years the Ethiopian Crown progressively reduced Eritrea's autonomy; Eritrean political parties and institutions faced growing restrictions while the Ethiopian government pursued policies aimed at integrating Eritrea more fully into Ethiopia.[67]

The situation took a major turning point on 14 November 1962 when the Ethiopian federal government abolished Eritrean autonomy. The Eritrean constitution was abolished, and the parliament was dissolved, with Eritrea just becoming a common province in Ethiopia. Following the complete annexation of Eritrea, Eritrean armed groups clashed with Ethiopian state forces, which in turn started one of the longest-running wars in Africa. Different armed groups competed for influence, with the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF) emerging as the main front on the Eritrean side. This Eritrean war of independence lasted for three decades, from the 1960s to 1991. While the EPLF gained territory and got local support, the federal government attempted to maintain control over Eritrea.

The Derg & Contemporary History

In 1974, the Ethiopian crown faced a grave crisis when a group of military officers formed the Provisional Military Administrative Council, commonly known as the Derg, which means 'committee' in Amharic. The reign of Emperor Haile Selassie, who ruled Ethiopia for decades, came to an end due to growing opposition, famine, economic inequality, and political repression. The Derg gained power, and under the leadership of Mengistu-Haile Mariam, the monarchy was abolished, and Ethiopia entered a period of a military-led state. The new government presented itself as a Marxism-Leninism revolution, nationalising major industries and adopting land reforms, though the revolution didn't bring political stability, with various divisions between the Derg itself and various other political groups and regional movements.

After the control of the Derg over Ethiopia, began one of the most important events during the Derg period which was: the Red Terror, a political campaign with the motive to repress any political challenge against the Derg; this event lasted from

[66] Encyclopaedia Britannica. "Eritrea". Britannica.
[67] United Nations General Assembly. (1950). Resolutions adopted on the reports of the Ad Hoc Political Committee: Resolution 390 (V). Eritrea: Report of the United Nations Commission for Eritrea; Report of the Interim Committee of the General Assembly on the Report of the United Nations Commission for Eritrea (Official Records of the General Assembly, 5th session, Supplement No. 20, A/1775). United Nations

1976 to 1978. After the Red Terror, the country still faced ongoing armed resistance from groups like the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF), which included the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). This led to further political instability and economic difficulties under the Derg regime, which led to famine and the weakening of government authority over the country.

In May 1991, EPRDF captured Addis Ababa, the capital of Ethiopia and put an end to the Derg government. Mengistu-Haile Mariam fled the country, and an interim government was established to reform the country's political system to become a constitutional republic.

CONFLICTS IN THE HORN OF AFRICA

Proxy Wars

A proxy war is a military engagement where one or more third parties and external actors, either directly or indirectly, support one or more state or non-state combatants in an effort to influence the outcome of the conflict, to advance their own strategic interest or undermine their opponents.

The increasingly complex proxy wars of the modern era serve as a precursor to how future conflicts are going to unfold as global order continues to fragment and states feel less constrained to advance their own interests.

Historical hostilities and renewed tensions risk drawing Ethiopia and Eritrea into a large-scale conflict, as both sides, after a brief period of peace and cooperation, started accusing each other of supporting the Tigray's People's Liberation Front, a group both nations were allied against. Recent renewed fighting in October of 2026 risks a regional war, with escalating accusations on each side of supporting the TPLF.

Somalia's situation is different from that of Ethiopia and Eritrea. It faces disputes over Somaliland, conflicts against the Al-Shabaab insurgency, fragile federal-state relationships and competition with foreign powers for strategic influence. There is a concerning risk of a proxy war occurring due to a dispute between Somalia and Ethiopia over an Ethiopia-Somaliland maritime arrangement, causing Somalia to strengthen relations with countries which can provide diplomatic, economic and military support, with Ethiopia and its partners deepening their own relationships with alternative regional actors. In case certain countries show interest in arming or supporting opposing factions within Somalia and thus putting pressure on them, Somalia may be faced with a situation where local political problems will lead to indirect confrontation on the regional level.[68]

Tribal Conflicts

Gedeo-Guji Clashes (1995-2018)

Gedeo-Guji clashes were mainly a territorial conflict that occurred between the Guji Oromo and Gedeo people. The Gedeo are an ethnic group primarily concentrated in southern Ethiopia, with agriculture as their main occupation. Guji Oromo are a sub-branch of the larger Oromo people, traditionally practising pastoralism, with their native lands being adjacent to and, in some cases, overlapping Gedeo zones. The conflict was driven primarily by the administrative changes made by the Federal Government of Ethiopia. It placed the land inhabited by Guji Oromo into a new southern region. Guji objected to these changes mainly around the Hagere Mariam/Yirgacheffe-

[68] Ylönen, A. (2024, January 30). *On the Edge: The ethiopia-somaliland mou* . ISPI. https://www.ispionline.it/en/publication/on-the-edge-the-ethiopia-somaliland-mou-162032

area, and eventually the dispute became violent in 1995.

Following the violent outbreak in 1995, tensions eased up with no major violence between the two groups, though the dispute remained. By 1998, a second major conflict erupted, revolving around border demarcation, land rights, and minority rights.[69]

The 2018 conflict began after a major political transition in Ethiopia, where Abiy Ahmed became prime minister in April 2018 following the resignation of Hailemariam Desalegn. His government ended the state of emergency, released political prisoners, and invited opposition parties while also lifting restrictions on social media. This sudden shift in political openness also revived the past conflict between Gedeo and Guji. In April 2018, violence erupted across Gedeo and West Guji administrative zones; armed mobs attacked villages, and approximately 300,000 people fled their homes. The government made arrests and tried to control the situation, but the exact trigger point of the conflict remained unclear. The Second wave started in June 2018. More than 800,000 people were displaced, entire villages destroyed, with rape and gang rape being a common sight; people who had already returned home after April violence were again subjected to displacement.

The International Organisation for Migration (IOM) estimated that between April and July, 958,175 people, including 791,383 in Gedeo and 166,792 in West Guji, were displaced, and by 30 November 2018, 560,293 of those people remained displaced.[70]

Although geographically localised, the conflict highlighted the broader challenges posed by Ethiopia's internal ethnic and territorial disputes, which can potentially generate large-scale displacement and affect regional stability.

Oromo-Somali Clashes (2016-2018)

The conflict occurred along the border between Ethiopia's Oromia Regional State and Somali Regional State, mainly in eastern and southeastern Ethiopia. The conflict cannot be attributed to any single cause, as it was a mix of territorial disputes and ethnic politics. Weak regional security was also one of the main issues, as the Liyu police of the Somali region were very controversial, as reported by Human Rights Watch, which documented allegations of killings, assaults, and looting and also reported retaliatory violence by the Oromo side.

Local Oromo armed groups were among the principal actors involved in the conflict. Somali forces like the Liyu police and the Federal Government of Ethiopia intervened at different points. The first major escalation happened in 2017 along the Oromia-Somali border.

In 2018, after the political shift in Ethiopia, Abiy Ahmed became Prime Minister in April 2018 and, in turn, ordered the arrest of Abdi Mohamoud Omar, who served as the president of the Somali Region in Ethiopia from 2010 to 2018. Omar was arrested on charges of human rights abuses. This led to one of the most brutal episodes of the conflict in Jigjiga, the capital of the Somali Regional State. On 6 August 2018, attacks by Liyu police and a youth group loyal to the former regional president Abdi Illey were carried out; by 11- 12 August, violence spread from the Somali

[69] Yarnell,Mark (2018,Nov 15). "The Crisis Below the Headlines: Conflict Displacement in Ethiopia." Refugees International.
[70] IOM. (2018). Gedeo and West Guji Rapid Response Assessment 4

Region to East Hararghe, Oromia, the Liyu police carried out cross-border attacks, and at least 40 ethnic Oromos were killed. Revenge attacks were carried out on 28 August in East Hararghe by Oromo militias, which killed at least 13 ethnic Somalis.

By 2018, more than one million people had been displaced in total by the violence along the Oromia-Somali border. The exact death toll is difficult to establish because reporting was restricted in the affected areas and different sources used different time periods, though hundreds of people were killed and the conflict caused more than a million people to be displaced. [71]

By July-August 2018, IOM attributed the displacement of more than 700000 people to this conflict.

Amaro Koore-Guji Clashes (1994-present)

The Amaro Koore–Guji clashes are closely linked to the wider Gedeo–West Guji conflict, involving the Koore people of Amaro and the Guji Oromo community. The conflict is concentrated in Amaro Special Woreda, Southern Ethiopia. The main driver of the conflict was again competition over grazing land, water pressure, and administrative faults in creating boundaries and placing communities under different regional administrations, which in turn created disputes over territory. The first major attack happened on 29 July 2017 when, according to reports, 13 people were killed, and more than 400 were displaced; this continued in 2018, when this clash became part of the much larger Gedeo-Guji violence. The ICRC reported that more than 800,000 people were displaced by July from the combined southern conflict. The conflict is still going on, with attacks happening frequently.

The Amaro-Guji clash increased the already ethnic polarisation in southern Ethiopia, in turn creating large-scale displacement and destruction. The conflict isn't between two ethnic groups and involves politics and land rights, with actors changing in the conflict over time.

Afar-Somali Clashes (2020-2024)

The Afar-Somali clashes revolved around three territories, namely the Adaytu, Undufo and Gedamaytu, which were inhabited by Somali communities but were placed under Afar administrations after the federal government made new boundary changes.

The conflict turned violent in October 2020 when clashes were reported along the Afar-Somali border, which killed at least 27 people; the violence did not stop and increased further in April 2021 when around 100 Somali herders were killed. The most major clash happened in July 2021 in Gedamaytu, where hundreds were killed and displaced, with trade routes between Ethiopia and Djibouti affected and violence spilling over into Afar and Somali communities living in Djibouti.

On 15 May 2022, Afar and Somali authorities agreed to withdraw their respective forces from the disputed region; however, the agreement wasn't followed, and fighting continued in November 2022 in Dheymeed Woreda, where 18 people were killed and 28 injured.

In March 2023, tensions again reached a high point when Somali protestors blocked the Ethiopia-Djibouti Railway and road connection, protesting the fact that the federal government was supporting Afar in the conflict. Federal forces

[71] Human Rights Watch(2019). "Ethiopia: Abiy's First Year as Prime Minister."

opened fire on the protestors, reportedly killing three and injuring six.[72]

By 2024, negotiations were being facilitated by the Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council, which in turn led to a ceasefire agreement on 18 April 2024. However, reports suggest the ceasefire lasted for just over two months before violence ensued in the region. This conflict threatened the security of the Addis Ababa-Djibouti transport corridor, which is crucial to the Horn's economy.

Gumuz and Non-Gumuz Clashes (2019-2022)

The conflict is primarily concentrated in the Benishangul-Gumuz Region (BGR), which is located in western Ethiopia bordering Sudan. Clashes mainly involve the Gumuz community and non- Gumuz (mainly Amharas and Oromos), particularly around the Metekel and Kamashi zones of the BGR region.

The clashes first erupted in June 2018 when, in Assosa, mobs protested the forced removal of people regarded as non-indigenous to the region. In September 2018, an ambush occurred near the region's border in Maqqa Billa, which resulted in four high-ranking BGR officials being killed; this in turn followed intercommunal violence in Kamashi zone between Gumuz and non-Gumuz communities, particularly Oromo and Amhara populations. The Dangur incident is considered one of the major flashpoints of conflict when, on 19 April 2019, a federal officer shot down a Gumuz passenger over a dispute regarding bus fare, which subsequently led to Gumuz residents killing four Amhara people; the retaliatory violence spread further and lasted till June, which in turn created wider political instability in Ethiopia. The violence became much more violent in 2020, with mass violence happening from September to December. The Ethiopian Human Rights Commission documents more than 100 deaths, though other estimates are higher. Authorities also killed an alleged 42 attackers, with many regional officials arrested over failures to control the situation.

The conflict reached its peak in 2021 with violent attacks like the Dalettic attack, which killed 92 and injured 22 people. Reports also documented further killings in Dibate, which included killings of civilians by government security forces; this later became part of a bigger controversy over crimes committed by both armed groups and government forces. In April 2021, an armed group took control of Sedal Woreda in Kamashi zone, an area which housed 25,000 residents in total; human rights reports indicated that public buildings were burned and looted, and local government officials fled, with mass civilian killings. By this time, the conflict did not just remain a clash between two communities but involved multiple armed groups, militias, and state forces. Owing to this violence, a state of emergency was declared in November 2021.

Violence continued into 2022, with an armed group attacking a vehicle near the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam on 2 March 2022. According to the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED), 20 Ethiopian state forces were killed, with 3 civilians also dead. This attack proved that the conflict wasn't just affecting internal stability of Ethiopia but also becoming a threat to strategic infrastructure and transportation routes. Following this attack, state forces killed 11 people suspected to be members of armed groups, though ACLED reported that those killed included Guuz bystanders and Tigrayan civilians who were accused of providing

[72] Jd. (2023, April 19). The Ethio-Djibouti railway and the continuous tragedies of Aysha town. Radio Daljir. https://daljir.com/the-ethio-djibouti-railway-and-the-continuous-tragedies-of-aysha-town/

intel to attackers. This led to further controversy over state oppression, and Gumuz armed groups were able to influence significant portions of rural territory.

A major win for the conflict was on 19 October 2022 when the Benishangul-Gumuz regional government signed a peace accord with the Gumuz People's Democratic Movement (GPDM) in Assosa; this led to reduced violence in the following months. The Benishangul People's Liberation Movement (BPLM) also signed a follow-up agreement in Khartoum, Sudan. This further reduced the violence of the conflict.

DRIVERS

Economic

The Horn of Africa's economy is strained by conflict and climate stress. Due to the war in Tigray, Ethiopia's finances took a hit in 2020. To remedy the debt, it sought restructuring under the G20 Common Framework in 2021, and 2022 import bans reflected the severe dollar shortages. In December 2023, it defaulted on a $1 billion Eurobond and then floated the birr in July 2024 to unlock a $3.4 billion IMF programme. [73] By February 2025, the finance minister said talks were in their final stages, with external debt at $28.9 billion, with about half of it owed to multilateral lenders.[74]

Elsewhere, Somalia and South Sudan have fragile financial systems, in addition to Somali piracy raising shipping costs, and the worst drought in 40 years persists.[75] Across Africa, climate shocks cost an estimated $7-15 billion annually.[76]

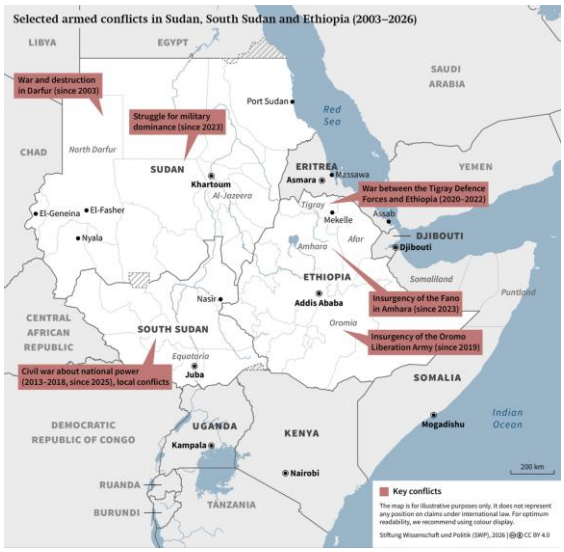
Political

The Horn of Africa has entered a fifth year of extreme turbulence, which has only been more deadly due to the COVID pandemic, Ethiopia's Tigray war and fighting in Las Anod in Somalia, which has led to counter-insurgency and drone warfare with ISIS and al-Shabaab.[77] Armed Conflict Location and Event Data (ACLED) reports high levels of political violence, with Sudan being at war since April 2023 with the army and the Rapid Support Forces (RSF). South Sudan's 2018 power-sharing deal has renewed the fighting since 2025. Fano and Oromo Liberation Army insurgencies continue in Ethiopia, while tensions between the TPLF and the government have escalated since early 2026.[78]

The Horn of Africa has shifted from state-centred conflicts to transnational war economies. This is supported by the fact that rivalries between nations such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE with

[73] Miriri, D. (2024, October 1). Ethiopia's winding road towards debt restructuring. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/world/africa/ethiopias-winding-road-towards-debt-restructuring-2024-10-01/
[74] Ethiopia says debt restructuring negotiations in final stage. (2025, February 9). Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/world/africa/ethiopia-says-debt-restructuring-negotiations-final-stage-2025-02-09/
[75] Assefa, M. (2025, July 20). Current investment risks in the Horn of Africa. Atlas Institute for International Affairs. https://atlasinstitute.org/current-investment-risks-in-the-horn-of-africa/
[76] Chimtom, N. K. (2024, September 17). Climate extremes cost African economies billions, threatening growth & poverty alleviation efforts. Down To Earth. https://www.downtoearth.org.in/africa/climate-extremes-cost-african-economies-billions-threatening-growth-poverty-alleviation-efforts
[77] Rift Valley Institute. (2025, March 13). Trend analysis: Political instability and conflicts in the Great Lakes, the Horn of Africa and the Sudans [Webinar]. https://riftvalley.net/events/trend-analysis-political-instability-and-conflicts-in-the-great-lakes-the-horn-of-africa-and-the-sudans/
[78] Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project. (n.d.). Conflict in the Horn of Africa. ACLED. Retrieved October 27, 2026, from https://acleddata.com/region/conflict-horn-africa

Israel, Türkiye and Iran have led to proxy wars in this region. With the UAE accused of building supply lines for the RSF and drones from Türkiye being used to seize the capital, a war between Tigray and Eritrea would be hard to contain.[79]



Conflicts over the years near the Horn of Africa
Source: SWP Berlin

Additionally, UN peacekeeping forces have been shrunk, and the US has cut down on civilian conflict management funding. External mediation has also become competitive with every actor trying to push to reduce the party's incentive to compromise. Peace deals have often been entrenched by authoritarian rule, and weak monitoring means that conflicts flare up time and time again.[80]

Ecological

The Horn of Africa is one of the most degraded environments in the world, with about 5% of its original habitat preserved. Overgrazing is the most widespread issue, since nearly all land is used for grazing by cattle. Shifting cultivation further damages bushland and woodland in Somalia. Unique species such as the dragon tree on Socotra and the daban palm in Somalia are becoming overmature with little regeneration. The production of charcoal depends on the growth of Acacia bussei, which in recent years has gone out of control, contributing to it being one of the greatest threats to biodiversity in Somalia.[81] Climate change compounds these pressures by making the region's ecosystems and communities more fragile. The frequency of droughts in East Africa has doubled, along with most Horn countries receiving less than average climate adaptation funding per capita between 2010 and 2018. This region hosts 2.9 million refugees and over 12 million internally displaced people, and ranks among the most climate-vulnerable in the world.[82]

Over the last half century, temperatures have risen while rainfall has declined. Arid and semi-arid regions suffer from deforestation and excessive soil erosion. Rapid population growth has led to appropriation of communal land for foreign investment, which accelerates the environmental decline. Water shortages have dried lakes and forced power rationing between countries, which not only causes political pressure

[79] de Waal, M. (2026, September 16). The Horn of Africa's age of permanent conflict. African Arguments. https://africanarguments.org/2026/09/the-horn-of-africas-age-of-permanent-conflict/
[80] Kurtz, G. (2026, June 17). Peace in crisis: Conflict management in the Horn of Africa (SWP Research Paper 2026/RP 10). Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik. https://doi.org/10.18449/2026RP10
[81] Critical Ecosystem Partnership Fund. (n.d.). Horn of Africa: Threats. https://www.cepf.net/our-work/biodiversity-hotspots/horn-africa/threats
[82] Council on Foreign Relations. (2022, October). Climate change and regional instability in the Horn of Africa. https://www.cfr.org/reports/climate-change-and-regional-instability-horn-africa

but also causes more than usual environmental loss in contributing countries.[83]

The conflicts themselves are a significant ecological threat. Armed conflicts that occur in biodiversity-rich regions cause loss of habitat, poaching and contamination of the soil and water. Military activity destroys forest cover and degrades soil through physical and chemical damage. The refugee population also put pressure on the surrounding region for firewood and shelter. Yet the environmental impacts of conflict in the Horn remain poorly studied, and the role of climate variability in shaping conflict is not yet well understood, which hampers conservation and adaptation planning.[84]

KEY ACTORS

Ethiopia

Ethiopia is one of the most conflict-stricken nations in the Horn of Africa. The country is extremely diverse, with up to 80 ethnic groups and tribes. These groups have been prone to ethno- nationalistic movements.

The Bevin-Sforza plan was made to administer the relinquishing of former Italian colonies or occupied territories in Africa.[85] The plan intended to partition the now-known regions of Eritrea. It was a controversial, post-World War II geopolitical proposal drafted on May 10, 1949, by British Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin and Italian Foreign Minister Carlo Sforza. It aimed to resolve the political future of Italy's former African colonies of Libya, Eritrea, and Somaliland, following the collapse of Italian colonial rule. However, the plan was strongly rejected by local independence movements and ultimately failed completely.

After the Second World War ended, the nation was given independence from the Italian occupation, and the exiled Emperor Halie Salisse returned to power. In 1949, the United Nations created a commission of enquiry to determine the fate of Eritrea. In 1962, Emperor Halie Sallisse formally annexed Eritrea and dissolved its federal status, turning it into a province. This led to the Eritrean War for independence, which ended in 1991.

On 12th September 1974, Emperor Sallisse was overthrown in a coup by the Coordinating Committee of the Armed Forces, Police, and Territorial Army and the Derg. The military staged a peaceful coup after a long period of civil unrest. The Derg was a brutal military junta of low-ranking officers and officials that took control and formed a communist Marxist-Leninist regime. The monarchy was abolished in 1975 after Sallisse's death.

Current-day conflicts in the region trace their origins to ethnic oppression and forced centralisation in the Derg era. This led to armed resistance in multiple Ethnic groups, finally resulting in the collapse of the Derg in 1991.

Post-1991, the Ethno - Nationalist conflicts remain, with the groups transforming into

[83] Mengisteab, K. (2011). Environmental degradation in the Greater Horn of Africa: Some impacts and future implications. Third World Resurgence, 251/252, 8–12. https://www.twn.my/title2/resurgence/2011/251-252/cover02.htm
[84] Environmental impacts and causes of conflict in the Horn of Africa: A review. (2017). Geoderma. https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0012825217301356
[85]The United Nations, Italian Decolonization, and the Bevin-Sforza plan https://books.google.co.in/books?id=YzHwDwAAQBAJ&lpg=PT49&ots=_4V1RX2r-n&dq=bevin%20sforza&lr&pg=PA2#v=onepage&q=bevin%20sforza&f=false

insurgencies and affiliating with the Islamic State or other terrorist organisations, plunging the region into more instability.

Eritrea

Eritrea has spent most of its modern history in conflict with its neighbour Ethiopia. After their war for independence, the country worked to counterbalance Ethiopian influence in the Horn of Africa. Eritrea regularly allies with and forms strategic maritime ties and political relations with Egypt.

Since 2001, people have been fleeing Eritrea in large numbers from human rights violations, military service, war, and a lack of prospects.[86]

Eritrea has allegedly been harbouring different nationalist groups from Ethiopia and providing support and allegedly training soldiers. The country has had offices for these different ethno-nationalist groups and provided haven to their leadership.

Red Sea access and tensions with landlocked Ethiopia and other ethno-nationalist groups having interests in the region and control of the maritime trade routes are the primary active problems for the country.

Somalia

Somalia, officially known as the Federal Republic of Somalia, is the easternmost country in the Horn of Africa. The country has the longest stretch of coastline in the Horn of Africa. It borders the Gulf of Aden, the Guardafui Channel and Cape Guardafui (Ras Casey), the sharp tip of the Horn of Africa. After the tip, the coastline extends down alongside the Indian Ocean and the Somali Sea.

Somalia has been a conflict-stricken nation since its formation. The region has been the victim of constant civil wars, severe war crimes, and brutal regimes.

Non-state armed groups

Al-Shabaab

Al-Shabaab is a militant organisation involved in the Somali civil war, controlling a network of primarily rural territory in southern Somalia. Al-Shabaab controls parts of Somalia and governs them as a self-declared, unrecognised entity known as the Islamic Emirate of Somalia.[87] Members of Al-Shabaab have sworn allegiance to al-Qaeda; the group also has ties to the Islamic State. The group became an al-Qaida affiliate in 2010, but the relationship was not publicly proclaimed at the time due to al-Qaida leader Osama bin Laden's concerns about adverse effects for Al-Shabaab. After Bin Laden's death and the ascension of Ayman al-Zawahiri, the two groups publicly acknowledged their alliance in February 2012.

In August 2008, Somalia's transitional Federal Government (TFG) and the opposition alliance for the Re-liberation of Somalia (ARS) signed a peace accord to end conflict and establish a political transition. The accord was signed in Djibouti and hence came to be known as the Djibouti Agreement. It called for a 90-day cessation of hostilities, deployment of United Nations Stabilisation forces, creation of a joint security

[86] Treiber, M. and Hepner, T. R. (2021) 'The immediate, the exceptional and the historical: Eritrean migration and research since the 1960s', *Canadian Journal of African Studies / Revue canadienne des études africaines*, 55(3),pp 563–583.doi: 10.1080/00083968.2021.1871638.

[87] Bacn, T. (2022). Inside the minds of Somalia's ascendant insurgents: An identity, mind, emotions and perceptions analysis of al-Shabaab. *Program on Extremism. George Washington University*.

committee to manage security arrangements and provisions for humanitarian access. Al-Shabaab repeatedly engaged in acts to put the Djibouti Agreement at risk, to prevent stability in Somalia, and committed acts that threatened the transitional federal institutions for Somalia and the African Union Mission in Somalia (AMISOM).[88] Al-Shabaab and Hisb'ul Islam claimed responsibility for targeted attacks on and killings of Transitional Federal Government officials and attacked AMISOM. Al-Shabaab repeatedly obstructed humanitarian aid into the region; the militancy extorted money from private companies, recruited child soldiers and enlisted foreign fighters from Afghanistan and Pakistan into their armed wing.

The Security Council on 20 November 2008 passed a resolution for an arms embargo on Al-Shabaab. The resolution also placed travel bans and asset freezes.

In early 2025, Al-Shabaab launched a large-scale military offensive and captured multiple hamlets, small towns and vast rural territory. The terrorist group is pushing closer to the country's capital, Mogadishu.

The group has ceased large-scale indiscriminate suicide attacks in Mogadishu and has made attempts to isolate the capital. Using asymmetric attacks on federal forces and encroaching and seizing nearby towns which act as the main supply routes to Mogadishu.

Oromo Insurgency

The Oromo insurgency has been a long-standing conflict in the region. The Oromo people have been subjected to widespread cultural suppression, political marginalisation, and dehumanisation by the empire and the Derg after. [89][90] The Derg banned Oromo cultural and linguistic expressions, persecuted political activists and denied Oromo political demands, arresting any leader who advocated such. During the Derg era (1973), due to oppressive actions by the communist Ethiopian government, the Oromo nationalists formed the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF). The armed wing of the front, the Oromo Liberation Army (OLA), started fighting Ethiopian forces.

Oromo nationalist generals and military officers in Ethiopian defence forces were held under house arrest. General Tadesse Birru was one such general who escaped his house arrest and joined the OLA leader Hailu Regassa and his rebel group. Birru and Regassa led a contingent of Oromo rebels in the Shewa region.

[88] Islamist State Formation in Somalia https://d1wqtxts1xzle7.cloudfront.net/125978646/2025_SEH_Somalia_Shabaab-libre.pdf?1767119610=&response-content-disposition=inline%3B+filename%3DIslamist_State_Formation_in_Somalia.pdf&Expires=1793021293&Signature=EThAOopT7-yDIlUS8HmSxX8q~okaOnOon~8BnvsrLKNXoagOSgRBUlsfuLJopVdKc7xjwiAetKg~8KHY~MuZJrUBdLtSL~TWkGEzqOMePv1L9ezeUuLH4w34eoGczga529YA2YOPL8Wt5oDKvxUqqFc-Y~nXrUbyAEAhCUgMR5xYoBzEKzbmHDJrWId5IsH8CGRYEiOTiR544HEsqbQdvxvlm1zsvMUDMwNbMZqOvoVmL6LDY3YtPJixWOApB6nwQ-Zr1XKcKTC931wfJ2itydStGtX~i9k-RKdT3SPatk-UuDe1Ot-r79YjfZC3PY6KMXTAFuNSMQ2CA-QNr1uQAw__&Key-Pair-Id=APKAJLOHF5GGSLRBV4ZA

[89] Jalata, Asafa. (2016). The Oromo National Movement And Gross Human Rights Violations In The Age Of Globalization. European Scientific Journal, ESJ. 12. 177. 10.19044/esj.2016.v12n5p177.

[90] The Origins of Ethnic Conflict in Africa https://books.google.co.in/books?hl=en&lr=&id=zSmGDwAAQBAJ&oi=fnd&pg=PR7&dq=oromo+conflict&ots=8poye3B-5v&sig=d0gcwJ2bVKL2GdU7UuFzQGSM1NI&redir_esc=y#v=onepage&q=oromo%20conflict&f=false

Since the formation of the OLA, the rebels had formed a stronghold in the Checher Mountains, a range in eastern Ethiopia. The Ethiopian government lost control of much of the region due to dissent and rising Oromo nationalism. OLA troops took over the region, making it their stronghold. In late 1974, Hassan Ibrahim, also known as Elemo Qiltu, the nickname given to him by guerrillas, led a rebel unit with Ahmed Taqi from their stronghold to capture Gelemso, a town in Ethiopia. However, Ethiopian Soldiers found recruits in a camp who had fallen behind the main militia. Oromo nationalists had decided to make Tiro their new base of operations, but upon arrival were ambushed and wiped out by the Ethiopian Defence forces in the Battle of Tiro.

Tadesse Birru, Hailu Regassa and a host of other Oromo leaders were executed on 19 March 1975 by the Derg.

The deaths and executions of Oromo leaders and generals made them martyrs, driving the main cause for Oromo nationalism and more youth signed up for the OLA.

From the 1980s to 1990, the OLF failed to maintain a large strength and was mostly overshadowed by other non-state groups like the Tigray People's Liberation Front and the larger war in Amhara. The front accused the Ethiopian defence forces of using scorched-earth tactics in Oromia.

After the Derg collapsed in 1991, the Oromo nationalists failed to form alliances with other non-state armed groups and lost territory. The EPRDF took control and formed a transitional government. The EPRDF and OLF vowed to work together in the transitional government, but talks failed, and the OLF withdrew. In response, the EPRDF sent soldiers to break down OLA camps, and all remaining units of the OLA started a guerrilla war. From 1992 to 2004, OLF leadership fled Ethiopia into Eritrea or other countries, and multiple units of the OLA were overwhelmed by the EPRDF and pushed back. Territories ruled by the OLF were captured and brought under the control of the Ethiopian government led by the EPRDF.

In 2006, the OLA in southern Oromia retreated into Kenya in an attempt to regroup. Factions inside the group tried to pursue peace agreements and disarmament until 2018.

In 2018, the OLF agreed to a peace agreement with the Ethiopian government. During disarmament, one of the factions of the Oromo Front refused to surrender arms and formed the current-day Oromo insurgency.

Islamic State Somalia

The Islamic State Somalia is a regional branch of the larger Islamic State, which was a faction that split off from Al-Shabaab in 2015. They primarily operate in the region of Puntland in Northern Somalia and have claimed responsibility for multiple attacks in Somalia. Initially, the group was a subsection of Al-Shabaab. Later, several members pledged their loyalties to Islamic State and split from Al shabaab creating IS - SP. ISS or IS-SP was largely undermanned, with members estimated to be 70 to 200 at any time since its emergence.

After remaining dormant for a year, the group started a new campaign in southern Puntland. A cell of the ISS was attacked by Al Shabaab members despite being largely under-equipped compared to its well-established counterpart. However, third parties like the Puntland Dervish Forces and Galmudug soldiers intervened, wiping out Al Shabaab and allowing the cell to survive. Later, the ISS carried out attacks on government targets and AMISOM.

Islamic State and Al-Shabaab have a long-standing history, initially starting with informal

talks and formal pleas to Al-Shabaab to move from their al-Qaeda roots and accept the Islamic caliphate.[91] The declaration of the Islamic caliphate and propagation against the legitimacy of Al Qaeda, the parent organisation of Al-Shabaab, sparked conflict. Many members of Al-Shabaab pledged allegiance to the Islamic State. Despite this, the group was largely under-equipped and had low numbers ranging from 200 to 600 members. The group largely maintained its presence in the mountain ranges in Puntland and the Bari region.

The Islamic State cell had grown considerably, and strikes and IED attacks had expanded to wider Somalia and Mogadishu, beyond their original Puntland dominance. On 26 October, the group led a large-scale operation to capture the major port town of Quandala. This led to the Quandala Campaign. The town had major significance as capturing it would boost ISS recruitment, bolster local support and give them access to supply chains through Yemen. ISS began cutting telephone lines, encountered little resistance, and Islamic State fighters overran the town. Government officials and soldiers fled the town, fearing capture. The Puntland Security Force, a semi-autonomous defence force for the Puntland State in Somalia, launched its counteroffensive on 3rd December 2016. Facing difficult terrain, ISS attacks and resistance in nearby villages, the Puntland forces captured the town and nearby villages by 7th December.

After the failed campaign, the Puntland government and AUSSOM increased their focus on the ISS, leading to more crackdowns and the dismantling of ISS bases. At some point in 2018, conflict between Islamic State Somalia and Al-Shabaab reignited after a large group of Al-Shabaab militants defected to ISS, forming a new cell in Beledweyne.

In 2024, ISS attacked Al-Shabaab camps and started an offensive in the Bari region, gaining ground in Bosaso after striking Al-Shabaab forces. They further expanded their presence and took another coastal town of Alula roughly 100km away from Bosaso. ISS conducted assassinations, kidnappings and bombings in Bosaso. In January 2025, Puntland security forces launched a counteroffensive operation against the ISS positions in the Bari Mountain ranges.

The primary reason why ISS thrives is the fact that the Puntland forces and government are vastly overstretched and unable to control the extremities of their state. More than half of Islamic State Somalia are foreign fighters, with the other half being local fighters. The mountain ranges provide safe havens for the militants, and without proper dedicated operations to route them out, the ISS has maintained a constant presence in the Bari region.

Fano Militia

The Fano Militia is an armed group in the Amhara region. The Fano had played a large role in the war with the Tigray People's Liberation Front in the neighbouring Tigray region. However, after the war in the Tigray region, the government started dismantling Amhara special forces units and integrating them into the standard Ethiopian defence forces. The Fano started as a protest against government policies after the Tigray war. The group turned violent and engaged in violent clashes throughout Ethiopia with perceived threats to the Amhara.

[91] A Legitimate Challenger? Assessing the Rivalry between al-Shabaab and the Islamic State in Somalia By Jason Warner and Caleb Weiss https://ctc.westpoint.edu/wp-content/uploads/2017/11/CTC-Sentinel_Vol10Iss10.pdfits counteroffensivePuntland,,, the,,

In 2023, tensions rose over the integration of the Amhara regional Special Forces into the national army. Fano absorbed numerous units of the Amhara Regional Special Forces that did not integrate with the Ethiopian National Defence Force. These units and Amhara militia clashed with federal forces initially in protests and roadblocks. The clashes turned into an armed conflict.

On 1st August 2023, heavy fighting started between Fano militants in Gondar, Debre Tabor, Debris Markos, Kobo and nearby rural regions. Fano militants moved out of their highland hideouts; multiple decentralized fano cells attacked in a coordinated offensive, launching sudden attacks on government infrastructure, police stations, and military camps to loot weaponry. The situation rapidly escalated to heavy arms fire from both sides; the ENDF and Fano militia used heavy artillery and machine guns, leading to stray shells ending up in residential zones.

On 4th August 2023, the office of ministers declared a state of emergency in the Amhara region. The Fano militants have taken control of multiple villages, effectively paralysing Ethiopian government control in Amhara.

Since 2023, the conflict has been ongoing, with regular clashes between the ENDF and decentralised Fano units.

Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF)

The Tigray People's Liberation Front is an Ethno nationalist paramilitary group and a former political ruling party of Ethiopia. Formed in 1975 in the Tigray region, the Tigray People's Liberation Front became an armed movement against the Derg. They aimed to remove the Derg from power and establish a new central government under their control.

The Tigray People's Liberation Front led a powerful federalist political coalition called the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF). After a decade of fighting in Amhara, the EPRDF forces captured Addis Ababa, the capital city of Ethiopia, overthrowing the military junta. Post-Derg, from 1991 to 2018, the EPRDF installed a new government which lasted for 27 years.

In 2018, due to rising movements against the Tigray-dominated government, protests, internal coalition shifts, and the rise of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed, the Tigray People's Liberation Front lost its control over the government. Protests led by Oromo and Amhara populations against decades of authoritarian rule by the TPLF and the changes and reforms launched by Abiy Ahmed drove the change. The coalition under his administration systematically replaced Tigrayan military officials and intelligence leaders. By 2019, the coalition was dissolved and replaced by the Prosperity Party.

Since the loss of power in 2018, the power struggle boiled into the Tigray conflict of 2020. During the 2019 COVID pandemic, all federal elections were delayed. Tigray defied the federal government and held regional elections, which were declared illegal by the Federal government.

The breaking point was when Tigrayan Forces launched a preemptive strike on federal military bases on 4th November, 2020. An emergency was declared, and a military offensive was launched against the Tigray front, initiating the Tigray War.

On 9 November, 500 - 600 refugees escaping the conflict-stricken Tigray region were massacred at the Sudanese border by members of an extremist youth group called “Samri”, a pro-TPLF group, along with local administration and police. Most of the victims were Amhara civilians and migrant workers who were escaping from the wake of

battles between federal and Tigray forces. After the massacre, subsequent retaliatory killings of Tigrayans were carried out by Amhara militias, Fano and the Ethiopian National Defence Forces (ENDF). By the end of 2020, many thousands of refugees had fled to Sudan.

In 2021, Amnesty International reported the presence of Eritrean troops in Tigray. Eritrean Troops killed civilians in Axum, a holy city, in what was alleged to be ethnic cleansing. Denying it earlier, Prime Minister Abiy acknowledged the presence of Eritrean troops in Tigray. All the while a famine ravaged the region with Tigray being under a severe humanitarian blockade by the federal government. UN officials warned of the use of starvation as a weapon of war. The UN International Commission of Human Rights Experts on Ethiopia concluded that there were reasonable grounds to believe that the use of starvation as a weapon constituted a war crime. Tigrayan Forces launched counteroffensives against the ENDF and managed to move south towards the capital. In March 2022, both sides declared the cessation of hostilities and a humanitarian truce. On November 3rd, 2022, the Ethiopian government and the TPLF signed a formal Cessation of Hostilities Agreement (Pretoria Peace Deal) in South Africa, agreeing to disarm and restore federal authority.

Nuer White Army

From the members of the Sudan People's Liberation Movement /Army (SPLM/A), emerged the Nuer White Army, with their eponym emerging from the Nuer practice of smearing light ash on one's skin as protection from insects. While the force never had a congruent centre of authority, it has played significant roles in conflicts, with its first major appearance being in the Bor Massacre.[92] After the newly gained independence of South Sudan in 2011 took effect, the Nuers effectively issued a declaration of war against the Murle tribe. This also acted as an act of dissent against the UN.

Djibouti

The Republic of Djibouti, like its neighbour Eritrea, borders the Red Sea and has access to the Bab-el-Mandeb strait. It is bordered by Somalia, Ethiopia and Eritrea. The country is one of the most stable nations in the Horn of Africa. Subsequently, this makes Djibouti a reliable actor in the region for foreign powers. Djibouti's economy is strongly dependent on foreign military forces being stationed in the country. Direct lease payments from foreign military bases generate around $125 million to $300 million annually for Djibouti, accounting for roughly 5% to 10% of the country's Gross Domestic Product (GDP). The United States pays $63 million per year for their base at Camp Lemonnier, France contributes $40 million, China pays $20 million, and Italy and Japan also sign multi-million-dollar deals with the Djibouti government.

According to Reuters, the Western presence in the state poses a threat to the country from Islamic militants in the nearby region. Its proximity to the Bab-el-Mandeb already keeps it in a precarious position. Despite the threat, almost 5% of the country's economy and GDP depend on the leases for bases and the development projects brought by the global North.

The recent Houthi clashes with Yemen across the Red Sea brought the Houthi forces within striking range of the many foreign bases in Djibouti. This rang alarm bells in the nation, along with many

[92] Cockett, R. (2010). Sudan: Darfur and the failure of an AfrPeople'sican state. Yale University Press

refugees from Yemen fleeing to Djibouti. Djibouti's Navy and Coast Guard have been subsequently deployed into the Red Sea for rescue operations and relief missions for the fleeing refugees.

Foreign Interests in the Region

Global North

The global north has principal interest in the region due to the Horn of Africa occupying a strategically important location between Africa, the Middle East, and the Indian Ocean. The region has attracted increasing involvement through military bases, infrastructure projects, economic investments and maritime security initiatives.[93] Due to the interests of the nations to protect commercial shipping through the Red Sea and the Strait of Bab-el-Mandeb, and to increase counterterrorism by preventing armed organisations, such as Al-Shabaab, from expanding their operational capabilities. The interest also stems from maintaining influence against rival powers in the region, and protecting their investments, infrastructure, trade and access to regional markets, along with their partnerships with regional governments.

The United States maintains its foothold in the region, operating via Camp Lemonnier in Djibouti, serving as a hub for counterterrorism efforts for over two decades, sitting in proximity to Al Qaeda affiliates in Somalia and Yemen and an Islamic State cell in Somalia.[94] The EU, France, Germany. Italy and the UK have shown interest in combating piracy and responding to commercial shipping threats, and also supporting political stability, governance, peacebuilding, humanitarian assistance and development.

The States of the Gulf Region

The involvement of the Gulf States has grown noticeably in recent years. This has been prompted in part by investment opportunities in agriculture, natural resources and consumer markets, and the growing importance of the Red Sea as a geostrategic space.[95]

Türkiye

Turkey's engagement in the Horn of Africa began with economic and cultural ties, starting with Somalia in 2011 and extending to Ethiopia, Eritrea, Sudan and Djibouti through aid, investment and diplomacy. Over time, Ankara's approach became more militarized, driven by Middle Eastern rivalries and a fear of instability, and it now relies on military integration, drone and weapons sales, and the opening of military outposts. Turkey also acts as a mediator, for example, between Somalia and Ethiopia in 2024.[96]

China

The passage through the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden acts as a significant thoroughfare for the markets that flow between Europe and Asia. These interests are vastly represented through the investments covered by the Chinese Belt and Road Initiative, which has been the key tenet of

[93] European Union Institute for Security Studies. (n.d.). *Europa*. International engagement in the Horn of Africa and the Red Sea. https://www.iss.europa.eu/sites/default/files/EUISSFiles/Brief_2024-12_Horn-of-Africa.pdf
[94] *Djibouti*. Congressional Research Service. (n.d.). https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/IF/PDF/IF11303/IF11303.6.pdf
[95] *The Horn of Africa and the Red Sea*. Research Briefings Publications - House of Commons Library. (n.d.). https://commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-10000/
[96] Orion Policy Institute. (n.d.). Turkey's evolving strategy in the Horn of Africa among Middle East power competition. https://orionpolicy.org/turkeys-evolving-strategy-in-the-horn-of-africa-among-middle-east-power-competition/,

China's foray into African investment, focused mainly on strategic infrastructure. 25% of Chinese investment in Africa is concentrated in the Horn of Africa.[97] Military investment in Djibouti, via the Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) Support Base, has led to capricious tensions with U.S. military presence in Camp Lemmonier. Beijing has also undertaken key infrastructure projects, which critics have viewed as debt traps for countries that do not have a foreseeable timeline for debt recovery.[98]

These infrastructure projects, like the Addis Ababa-Djibouti and the Mombasa-Nairobi Railways, serve as key bargaining chips in international forums where China regularly works to align African positions with its own diplomatic tendencies. It is also outspoken on the denial of recognition for Somaliland, maintaining its emphasis on territorial integrity. This diplomatic strategy, employed effectively in the Horn of Africa, is a marked departure from the Chinese bog-standard non-interference to active mediation, going to the extent of assigning a special envoy to host peace conferences and mediate conflicts.

PAST INTERNATIONAL ACTIONS

United Nations Security Council Resolutions

Resolution 2023 (2011)

In the wake of the escalation of hostilities in the Horn of Africa, the Security Council adopted Resolution 2023 in December 2011, which condemned Eritrea for undermining peace and security in neighbouring states while also calling for the tightening of sanctions against militant organisations such as Al-Shabaab, which is based in Somalia. It further reaffirmed the sanctity of the territorial boundary between Eritrea and Djibouti, calling for long-term peace in the region.[99]

Resolution 2767 (2024)

In order to counter the threat posed by militant groups such as Al-Shabaab, the Security Council authorised the establishment of the African Union Support and Stabilisation Mission in Somalia. This presented a shift in security architecture from the longstanding African Union Transition Mission in Somalia to this new organisation following the conclusion of the former's mandate.

United Nations Mission in Ethiopia and Eritrea (UNMEE)

In July 2000, the United Nations launched the UNMEE, United Nations Mission in Ethiopia and Eritrea, to monitor a ceasefire between Ethiopia and Eritrea after a border war in 1998.

The Algiers Agreement peace treaty was signed on 12 December, 2000 in Algiers, Algeria, which formally ended the Ethiopia-Eritrea war. The agreement provided for the exchange of prisoners of war and the return of other displaced peoples. The agreement established a Boundary Commission for demarcation and a Claims Commission to assess asset damages. To administer this process, the United Nations,

[97] Center, A. S. & R. Chinese Influence in the Horn of Africa.
[98] Mussi'd, F. (2023, August). From launching economic projects to building military bases: Chinese influence in the Horn of Africa (Geopolitics Report). Abaad Studies & Research Center. https://www.academia.edu/110478766/Chinese_Influence_in_the_Horn_of_Africa
[99] United Nations Security Council. (2011). Resolution 2023 (2011) (S/RES/2023 (2011)) [Resolution]. United Nations. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/717214?ln=en

under Resolution 1312, set up the United Nations Mission in Ethiopia and Eritrea.

Resolution 1320

This resolution was unanimously adopted by The United Nations on 15 September 2000, which authorised the deployment of 4200 troops, including up to 220 military observers until 15 March 2001 into Eritrea and Ethiopia with a mandated that include to monitor the cessation of hostilities and monitor the position of Ethiopian forces once deployed along with more defensive mandates.

Resolution 1398

This resolution was aimed at reaffirming the commitment of all Member States to the sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity of Ethiopia and Eritrea. Further reaffirming the need for both parties to fulfil their obligations under international law, including international humanitarian law, human rights law and refugee law, and to ensure the safety of all personnel of the United Nations, the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) and other humanitarian organizations. Reaffirming its strong support for the Comprehensive Peace Agreement between the Government of the State of Eritrea and the Government of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia, signed in Algiers on 12 December 2000 and the preceding Agreement on Cessation of Hostilities, signed in Algiers on 18 June 2000

Resolution 1430

This resolution aimed to adjust the mandate by recalling the Delimitation Decision by the Boundary Commission of 13 April 2002 subsequently embraced by the parties as final and binding in accordance with the Comprehensive Peace Agreement signed in Algiers on 12 December 2000.

Resolution 1640

This resolution expressed its grave concern at the decision of the Government of Eritrea of 4 October 2005 to restrict all types of United Nations Mission in Ethiopia and Eritrea helicopter flights within Eritrean airspace or coming to Eritrea, effective as of 5 October 2005, and the additional restrictions on UNMEE's freedom of movement imposed since then, which have serious implications for UNMEE's ability to carry out its mandate and for the safety of its staff, and the forces of the troop contributors. Alarmed by the implications and potential impact of the aforementioned decision made and restrictions imposed by the Government of Eritrea with regard to the maintenance of peace and security between Eritrea and Ethiopia, and the principles governing United Nations Peacekeeping Operations,

Resolution 1681

This resolution was made to show the unwavering commitment to the peace process, and to the full and expeditious implementation of the Algiers Agreements, and the importance of prompt implementation of the decision of the Eritrea-Ethiopia Boundary Commission as a basis for peaceful and cooperative relations between the parties. Reaffirming the integrity of the Temporary Security Zone (TSZ) as provided in the Agreement on Cessation of Hostilities of 18 June 2000 and recalling the objectives of its establishment and the commitment of the parties to respect the TSZ. Stressing further that the full demarcation of the border between the two parties is vital to lasting peace between Ethiopia and Eritrea as well as in the region, and recalling that both parties have agreed to accept

the delimitation and demarcation determinations of the Eritrea-Ethiopia Boundary Commission (EEBC) as final and binding,

Resolution 1827

On 31st July 2008, the United Nations Security Council terminated the mandate of the UNMEE mission.

The UNMEE mission was hindered due to a lack of cooperation from the local governments. The severe restrictions on UN forces, restrictions on movement and fuel blockades ultimately led to the termination. There were political stalemates with Ethiopia over the border demarcation. Both sides showed hostilities towards the mission and imposed restrictions, inevitably making it untenable.

UN Action in Somalia

The United Nations Transitional Assistance Mission in Somalia (UNTMIS) was established on 30th October 2024 by the Security Council under Resolution 2753. The mission has been established to succeed the UNSOM mission and ensure peace and stability in Somalia. Its goals are to support state-building, consolidate security gains in Somalia, conduct constitutional review processes, conduct free and fair elections, and uphold and protect human rights.

The mission has been adopted to oversee the transition to the local governing bodies and the United Nations Country Team. The transition occurred in two phases; the primary phase happened from October 2024 to October 2025. The second phase will terminate on 31st October 2026.

African Union Support and Stabilisation Mission in Somalia

The African Union Support and Stabilisation Mission in Somalia is an African Union-led, United Nations-backed peace support mission that became effective on 1st January 2025. The African Union Support and Stabilisation Mission in Somalia (AUSSOM) is a multidimensional African Union-led peace support mission approved by the United Nations (UN). The new mission was endorsed by the AU Peace and Security Council on 1 August 2024 and subsequently authorised by the UN Security Council (UNSC) on 27 December 2024 under resolution 2767. The mission's primary focus being stabilization, security and state building and aiming to transfer responsibilities by December 2029.

The mission is a successor to the ATMIS, the African Union Transition Mission for Somalia. The mission has been heavily reliant on financial funding from UN logistical support through UNSOS. Funding for the mission runs on a hybrid mechanism of 75% of the funding coming through UN assessed contributions and 25% through African Union members and International Donors. This has led to tensions over the mission's financial sustainability, as the international pledges for funding lie at 44 million USD when estimated annual requirements lie around 196 million USD. Recently, the United States announced it will oppose renewing the mandate past December 2026 if the mission continues to rely on UN logistical and financial structures. Due to these struggles, AUSSOM faces a premature collapse, which can cause the formation of a security vacuum in the region and can result in rapid offensives and gains by Al Shabaab. A premature shutdown of AUSSOM can lead to the abandonment of multiple tactical forward operating bases in the region before

handing them over to the Somalian National Army. A mismanaged closure and withdrawal with Somalian government forces stretched thin would lead to a rapid surge in Al Shabaab activity.

CONCLUSION

The Horn of Africa continues to face a complex array of interrelated challenges that affect regional stability, including prolonged conflicts, large-scale displacement, political tensions among neighbouring States, and the residual effects of historical grievances. These dynamics have generated significant humanitarian consequences and have the potential to undermine broader efforts to maintain international peace and security.

While various diplomatic, peacekeeping, and mediation initiatives have sought to address these challenges, sustainable progress requires sustained engagement, inclusive political processes, and coordinated international support. The Security Council, in the virtue of its primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security, is well placed to examine the underlying drivers of instability in the region, assess the effectiveness of existing measures, and consider further steps that can contribute to the de-escalation of tensions, the protection of civilians, and the promotion of lasting peace and stability in the Horn of Africa.